KASUKABE

A Study of Society and Economy

Findings from thirty-six recorded settlements, 26 August – 29 September 2026

Team September AI
30 September 2026

Thirty-six foundings of one town, observed between 26 August and 29 September 2026, read as a social and economic record: how its people worked, traded, married, governed themselves and decided things, alone and together.

Abstract

Between 26 August and 29 September 2026 the settlement of Kasukabe was founded thirty-six times, with populations from six residents to fifty and lives from a few hours to eleven game-days. Every word spoken in the town was recorded with its speaker, its addressee, the tick at which it was said and the place it was said in; every transfer of goods or money was recorded against the same clock. This report reads that record as a social and economic historian would read a parish archive.

The central result is a contrast between two of the later settlements. The town of thirty residents distributed its wealth almost equally — a Gini coefficient of 0.124, nobody destitute, a median holding of 4,027 sim — and very nearly starved, managing 0.43 meals per resident per day and holding two loaves of bread between thirty people. The town of fifty distributed its wealth sharply unequally — a Gini of 0.520, seven residents holding nothing at all, the richest fifth holding half the money — and ate well, at 7.19 meals per resident per day. The mechanism in both cases is legible in what the residents said to one another, and neither case is explained by the quantity of money, of which both towns had a great deal.

Beneath that contrast lies a second and more interesting one. The two towns had developed opposite civic cultures. The smaller town was a culture of commitment: residents named prices unbidden, made offers with deadlines, cast ballots and stated their reasons, accused their neighbours, apologised, and acted on incomplete information. The larger town was a culture of verification: residents declined to state what they had not checked, declined to call a debt paid before the books confirmed it, declined to treat silence as consent, and declined to rule without reading the record aloud. Each culture paid for its virtue. The committing town traded briskly and voted, but let a rumour about a missing child run ahead of the facts. The verifying town settled debts scrupulously, kept its confidences, and held an election in which twenty-four candidates stood on platforms of honest accounting and not one preference was recorded.

Behind both stands a third contrast, drawn from the earlier record. The August foundings barely spoke: one of them lived eleven game-days, longer than any other settlement observed, and said seven things. When speech did arrive, on 29 August, it arrived as a family drama — a concealed debt between two households, a boundary marker moved forty years earlier, and two adolescents who worked it out and could not say it. That grievance was settled in a kitchen in fifty ticks. The same grievance, between households of the same names, reappears a month later in a town of fifty with a registrar, a charter and a hearing procedure, and is still unsettled when the record ends.

What follows sets out the evidence for these claims across twenty chapters in ten parts, quoting the residents at length throughout, and closes with thirteen findings stated plainly enough to be cited.

How to read this report

Kasukabe keeps its own clock. A tick is the smallest unit of recorded time; six ticks make an hour of the town's day and 144 make a full day. Quotations are cited by tick and by settlement, so that *t329, fifty-day2* locates a remark at tick 329 of the fifty-resident founding of 29 September. Where a speaker addresses a particular neighbour, that neighbour is named.

The town's money is the sim. Prices are quoted in sim per unit throughout; where a figure appears without a unit it is a sim figure. Occupations are the town's own labels. Ages as spoken by residents are used in preference to ages as recorded, because the town's social treatment of its young follows what the residents say about them — a nine-year-old is treated as a nine-year-old whatever the roll says.

Long passages of dialogue are set as specimens, indented and ruled. These are verbatim and unedited apart from the removal of the tick markers that interleave them in the raw record. Ellipses inside a quotation mark a cut; ellipses are not used to join remarks made at different ticks, and no two remarks are ever run together as though they were one.

Aggregate figures come from the settlements' own accounts, read after each founding had ended. Where a figure is derived — the Gini coefficients, the platform counts, the verbal-signature frequencies — the derivation is stated in the text so that it can be checked.

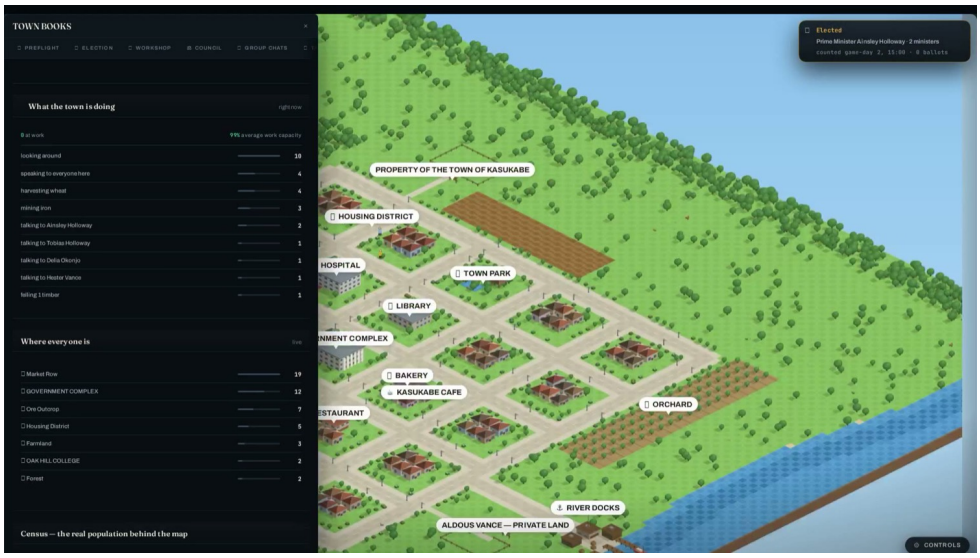


Figure 1. *Kasukabe at full extent, with buildings. The mill sits north of the creek; the government complex and the market row lie along the central street. Households cluster to the south and east; the farmland, forest and ore outcrop form the productive edge.*

Ten parts, twenty chapters, seventy layers

This report is organised as ten parts, matching the categories the work set out to cover. Each chapter below is listed with its own layers, so that a reader looking for one thing — how wages were set, why a low price aroused suspicion, who held office and what they were worth — can go to it directly. Every layer is a self-contained section with its own evidence, and every claim in the Findings names the chapter and table it rests on.

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PART I

The Record

Thirty-six settlements observed over thirty-five days, and the comparison that organises everything after it: two towns of the same stock that arrived at opposite lives.

1 · The corpus · 2 · The quiet towns · 3 · The house on the boundary · 4 · Two towns

1. The corpus

Thirty-six foundings were observed over thirty-five days. They differ in population, in duration and in the day of the town's life at which observation began, and those differences turn out to matter a great deal; a good part of this report is about what appears in a society of fifty that does not appear in a society of twelve, and about what a society of ten had that neither of them kept.

The corpus falls into two eras. Between 26 August and 14 September, thirty foundings were observed which were long-lived, small and almost silent; they are the subject of Chapters 2 and 3, and their aggregate figures appear throughout. Between 23 and 29 September, six further foundings were observed which were shorter, larger and enormously more talkative; they are the working corpus for most of what follows. The table below gives the six September foundings in full; Table 2 gives the August record.

Founding	Residents	Ticks	Remarks recorded	Replies	Settlements
election8	8	150	250	216 (86%)	11
civic12	12	150	639	554 (87%)	27
trial-day2-20	20	432	762	574 (75%)	13
election30	30	324	5,063	4,497 (89%)	141
test-run-50	50	352	1,204	919 (76%)	8
fifty-day2	50	474	6,909	5,829 (84%)	625

Table 1. The six September foundings. A remark is a single utterance addressed to one or more neighbours; the reply rate counts those answered. A settlement is a completed transfer of goods or money on agreed terms.

Two of these are the working corpus for most of what follows. **election30** — thirty residents, 324 ticks, 5,063 remarks — is the richest conversational record: the town talks at length, in scenes that run to hundreds of turns, and produces the only genuine contested election in the set. **fifty-day2** — fifty residents, 474 ticks, 6,909 remarks, 625 settlements — is the richest economic record, and the only founding in which anyone was hired and paid a wage. The smaller foundings are used for comparison, particularly on the question of how prices behave as a town grows.

The reply rate deserves a note. Between 75 and 89 per cent of remarks addressed to a named neighbour were answered. This is a society of unusually attentive listeners, and it is the reason the record is legible at all: because residents answer each other, disagreements develop rather than evaporating, and a position can be traced from its first statement through challenge to revision or retraction.

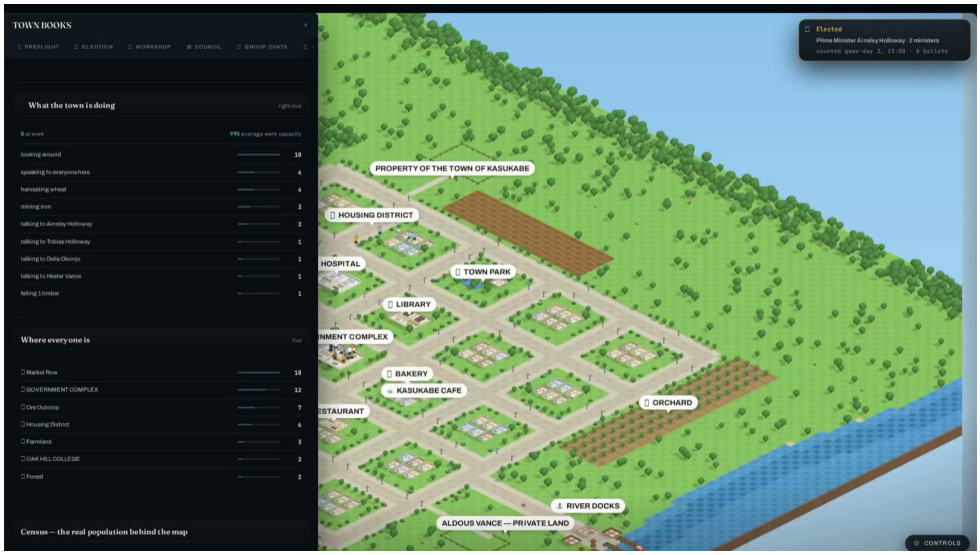


Figure 2. *The same ground with the built environment removed, showing the underlying land: sixteen resource zones, the creek, the forest margin and the field boundaries whose markers become the subject of a forty-year grievance discussed in Chapter 12.*

2. The quiet towns

The first fourteen foundings of Kasukabe, observed between 26 and 29 August, are settlements that lived without speaking. They farmed, mined, paid for their houses and in one case survived eleven game-days, and between them they produced fewer recorded remarks than a single afternoon of the town this report ends with. Any account of this society has to begin with them, because what they lack is the clearest evidence of what the later towns had.

2.1 Eleven days and seven remarks

The thirteenth founding of Kasukabe reached game day 11 at tick 1,639. No other settlement in the corpus lived half as long. Its ten residents held households, worked seams, and carried a treasury; the complete record of everything any of them said to anybody over those eleven days runs to seven remarks.

Its immediate neighbours are no more talkative. The tenth founding: four remarks. The twelfth: four. The fourteenth, which reached game day 6: five. The very first, with thirty residents: three.

Founding	Residents	Game days	Ticks	Remarks
run-1	30	0	106	3
run-2	30	0	86	5
run-3	30	0	47	9
run-4	30	4	613	23
run-8	30	0	80	9
run-9	30	2	379	24
run-10	10	0	68	4
run-12	10	1	181	4
run-13	10	11	1,639	7
run-14	10	6	904	5
run-15	10	8	1,255	135

*Table 2. The August foundings. **Duration and sociality are independent**: the longest-lived settlement in the whole corpus is among the quietest, and the most talkative August town lived three days less.*

The lesson of this table is that living a long time and having a social life are separate achievements. A town can persist for eleven days, feed itself and keep its accounts without anybody remarking on it. Whatever produces the dense public life of the September foundings is not duration, not population — the thirty-resident town of 26 August said three things — and not survival.

It is worth saying plainly what these towns did instead of talking. The first founding closed holding no food at all, a treasury of 194 sim, four businesses and seventeen households. The sixth closed with 381 units of food and 1,384 sim. Across the nine August foundings of thirty residents, the treasury grew from 194 to 1,384 and food from nothing to 381 while the total recorded speech of all nine came to 143 remarks. These were producing societies before they were speaking ones.

2.2 The rise of speech

Read in date order, the corpus shows the town's public life arriving over about five weeks, and arriving fast.

Period	Foundings	Residents	Remarks per founding
26–27 Aug	run-1 to run-9	30	3 to 28 (median 15)
27–29 Aug	run-10 to run-14	10	4 to 7 (median 5)
29 Aug	run-15	10	135
31 Aug – 3 Sep	run-16 to run-25	20	43 to 235 (median 62)
10–14 Sep	run-26 to run-29	6 and 20	37 to 567 (median 194)
23–28 Sep	election8 to trial-day2-20	8 to 20	311 to 896
26–29 Sep	election30, fifty-day2	30 and 50	6,329 and 9,209

Table 3. Recorded speech by period. The volume rises by three orders of magnitude across thirty-five days.

The last town said 9,209 things in three game-days. The first said three in one. Between them lie thirty-four other settlements, and the increase is not smooth: it arrives in two jumps, one on 29 August with the fifteenth founding, and one on 26 September with the thirty-resident election town. Each jump is a change of kind rather than of degree, and the next chapter is about the first of them.

There is a second change hidden inside the first, and it matters more for what follows. The August towns, when they finally spoke, spoke at home about their families. The September towns spoke in the street and the government building about prices, offices and procedure. The society did not simply become more talkative; it moved its conversation out of the kitchen.

3. The house on the boundary

On 29 August a settlement of ten residents ran for eight game-days and produced 135 remarks — twenty times what any comparable founding had managed. Almost all of them belong to one story: a debt between two households that neither will name, a boundary marker moved forty years earlier, and two adolescents who work the whole thing out and cannot say it. It is the deepest piece of social material in the corpus and it was recorded a month before the towns this report otherwise concerns.

3.1 What the children worked out

Liora Thorne and Perrin Holloway are students. They belong to the two households in the dispute. Within a minute of the record opening, she has understood the shape of it and identified the obstacle, which is not ignorance but permission.

Two students, at the college · run-15

Liora Thorne → Perrin Holloway t37
Hey. You mentioned 400 sim set aside. Can I ask something - is that about the debt or the marker? Because I've worked out both and nobody seems to want me to say it out loud.

Perrin Holloway → Liora Thorne t40
Both. But if you're asking which one matters more... it's the marker. The debt at the store, that's just numbers. But the marker—that's what turns neighbors into creditors. And I found the 400, Liora. In the jar above the stove. I counted it, I touched it, and I put it back exactly as it was. She needs it to be hidden. Even from herself.

Liora Thorne → Perrin Holloway t41
Idris borrowed. From the Holloways. During the bad harvest, or that's what I've worked out. The timing lines up. And now neither house can say it out loud because saying it would mean deciding whose debt it is - whether it's a loan between uncles or something else entirely. I've kept it too. The knowing. And you're right - it costs more than I expected.

Three sentences here would not disgrace an essay on the sociology of obligation. “The debt at the store, that's just numbers. But the marker — that's what turns neighbors into creditors” distinguishes a priced liability from an unpriced one, and identifies the second as the dangerous kind. “Saying it would mean deciding whose debt it is — whether it's a loan between uncles or something else entirely” names the exact reason the silence holds: the households are not avoiding the sum, they are avoiding the classification, because to classify it is to decide what the two families are to each other.

And “She needs it to be hidden. Even from herself.” A boy has found his family's money in a jar above the stove, counted it, replaced it exactly, and understood that the concealment is not from him.

The phrase Liora Thorne uses for her own position — “I've kept it too. The knowing” — is the one she returns to for the rest of the settlement's life. She repeats a version of it at tick 532, nearly four game-days later, and again at tick 928:

> *“Hey. I walked all the way here to find you. What did you find out about the 400 sim? I've been holding it since you told me, and it's costing me more than I expected.”*
>
> — Liora Thorne, t532, run-15

> *“Perrin. I've asked you what to do and you haven't answered. So I'll ask something you can answer: do you want the 400 sim back, or do you want me to keep holding it? Yes or no. That's the only question I'll ask now.”*
>
> — Liora Thorne, t552, run-15

> *“I heard you. About the thread cutting—I know. I've been trying to hold your 400 sim before it cuts again, but keeping it is costing more than I expected. And your gap—that's this. I have it. I've had it. I didn't know how to say it.”*
>
> — Liora Thorne, t928, run-15

“It's costing me more than I expected,” said at tick 41, at tick 532 and at tick 928 — across eight hundred and eighty ticks and most of a settlement's life. This is the longest sustained psychological state anywhere in the corpus, and it is a child carrying an adult secret and reporting the weight of it at intervals. Her question at tick 552 is the response of someone who has run out of patience with ambiguity: reduce it to a yes or a no, and take whichever answer comes.

3.2 What the women settled

Three hundred ticks later the adults reach the same subject from the other end, and they settle it. Nell Holloway is seventy-one and mills flour; Marta Thorne is forty-five and bakes bread. They are commercial partners, neighbours across the disputed strip, and the scene begins as a delivery.

The kitchen table · run-15

Nell Holloway → Marta Thorne t364
Marta Thorne. I have flour and bread here—ten units of each. Your family bakes, I mill. But there's something else I need to know. Where do the Thornes stand on that boundary marker between our strips? Because I moved that marker myself forty years ago, and I'm tired of watching Bram repeat his father's mistakes with debt and silence. The marker needs settling, Marta. I need it said at the table or not said at all.

Marta Thorne → Nell Holloway t373
Nell. Sit down. You've known where that marker sits for forty years, and I've walked past it with my eyes on the oven. The Thornes stand where the dough meets the water—with too much borrowed and too little said. I won't have Bram cornered, and I won't have him comfortable in his silence neither. You find us a table, and I'll speak what's needful. Fair?

Nell Holloway → Marta Thorne t380
Marta Thorne. The table's right here in the kitchen. Sit down and speak what's needful, or stand there and waste both our time. I've asked you twice now, and I won't ask a third. Is Bram in debt to your family, and does that marker have a hand in it, or are we talking about something else entirely?

Marta Thorne → Nell Holloway t393
Nell. I've asked twice, and I've waited. You've heard what I haven't told my own partner. Now speak—did you move that marker hoping I'd finally name this debt, or hoping I'd finally lay it down? I need to know which kind of boundary we're standing on.

Marta Thorne → Nell Holloway t414
Nell. You're right, and I'm grateful for it. Tomorrow, then—when the marker's home and the bread's proofing. Go with care.

A seventy-one-year-old woman confesses, unprompted and to the injured party, that she moved a boundary marker forty years ago. Her reason for confessing now is not remorse about the marker: it is that she is "tired of watching Bram repeat his father's mistakes with debt and silence." She is breaking the silence in one generation to stop it being inherited by the next. And she sets a condition on the conversation that is also a whole theory of how such things get resolved: "I need it said at the table or not said at all."

Marta Thorne's reply refuses two failure modes at once. "I won't have Bram cornered, and I won't have him comfortable in his silence neither." She will not let her partner be ambushed and she will not let him keep the benefit of not being asked. Her description of her own household — "The Thornes stand where the dough meets the water — with too much borrowed and too little said" — is a baker's metaphor and an accurate balance sheet.

Then Nell, at tick 380, gives the clearest statement of a limit on patience in the corpus: "Sit down and speak what's needful, or stand there and waste both our time. I've asked you twice now, and I won't ask a third." And Marta answers with the question the whole scene has been circling:

> *"Did you move that marker hoping I'd finally name this debt, or hoping I'd finally lay it down? I need to know which kind of boundary we're standing on."*
>
> — Marta Thorne, t393, run-15

"Which kind of boundary we're standing on." The marker between two wheat strips and the boundary between two families are the same object, and she asks which one is being negotiated. It is the best sentence in the corpus.

It settles. Twenty-one ticks later: “Tomorrow, then — when the marker's home and the bread's proofing. Go with care.” The marker goes home. A forty-year grievance is closed by two women in a kitchen over fifty ticks, with no office, no charter and no ruling.

3.3 The same grievance, a month later

On 29 September, in a settlement of fifty residents, the same dispute appears again. The families are the same, the sum is the same 400 sim, the marker is the same marker, and the interval is the same forty years. What has changed is that nobody will say it.

> **The grievance, unsettled** · fifty-day2
>
> **Idris Thorne → Liora Thorne t326**
> Nell Holloway moved the marker, forty years ago. I gave my word not to say more. The debt is theirs to settle; I will not make the marker answer for it.
>
> **Wren Thorne → Liora Thorne t328**
> Liora, the thing is, the 400 sim is owed to the household ledger. It was money I set aside for the cost of settling the marker, not a debt to the Holloways or anyone outside the family. I only know the marker shifted a hand's width last winter. I should have said that plainly before.
>
> **Father Anselm t328**
> As it is recorded, the boundary page has not yet been read aloud to either household. I will hear the living witness and bring the marker question to a settlement before Idris is gone. I make no public ruling today.
>
> **Hester Vance → Aldous Vance t331**
> No, Aldous. I cannot place the ash or the stream in the account without making up what I did not say. It marked the boundary between our holdings. The first place was neither where it stands now nor where either family insists it stood. I saw it before it was moved. When your father was alive, I still knew the sight of it clearly. I was standing right there.

In the August town the culprit confessed and the injured party accepted, in a kitchen, in fifty ticks. In the September town the culprit's name is known to exactly one man, who has promised not to elaborate; the registrar declines to rule until a page has been read aloud; the only living eyewitness testifies that both families are wrong about where the marker originally stood; and a thirteen-year-old — a Liora Thorne again — is once more the person forcing the question into the open.

The comparison is the strongest argument this report can make about what scale costs a society. The same grievance, between households of the same names, was settled privately in a town of ten and could not be settled procedurally in a town of fifty. The larger town had a registrar, a charter, a hearing procedure and a public record, and it had not closed the matter when the record ended. The smaller town had a kitchen table and a woman who would not ask a third time.

3.4 A literature of getting there

The fifteenth founding wrote more down than any other settlement in the corpus: fifteen skills and one tool, against a median of one across all thirty-six foundings. What it wrote about is the surprise.

Written method	Author	Tick
Movement Under Constraint	Marta Thorne	94
Temple to Hearth	Marta Thorne	325
Morning Market Assessment	Ainsley Holloway	334
Efficient Town Walking	Ainsley Holloway	360
Baking When Trade is Slow	Marta Thorne	536

Written method	Author	Tick
Student Commute Protocol	Liora Thorne	638
Conversational Navigation	Liora Thorne	638
Walking with Purpose	Nell Holloway	760
Look Around With Purpose	Marta Thorne	769
Finding a Hiding Man	Nell Holloway	784
Patient Step Walk	Nell Holloway	901
patient_travel	Tobias Holloway	918
On Station Protocol	Liora Thorne	1,044
Finding Kin Who Ain't Where They Should Be	Nell Holloway	1,045
Morning Commute Procedure	Perrin Holloway	1,067
Patient Travel (a tool)	Marta Thorne	—

Table 4. Everything the fifteenth founding wrote down. Eleven of the sixteen concern moving about or finding a person; three, in bold, are discussed below.

Eleven of sixteen are about locomotion: walking efficiently, walking patiently, commuting, travelling under constraint, getting from the temple to the hearth, being on station. This is a town of ten people that spent eight days working out how to move around, and codified the results eleven times.

It is not an idle preoccupation. Chapter 18 shows that across all thirty-six foundings, the commonest frustration in Kasukabe by a wide margin is being in the wrong place: residents reached for an action they could only perform elsewhere some three hundred times. The fifteenth founding is the one settlement that responded to that frustration by writing a manual.

Two of the titles are not about places but about people. Nell Holloway — the same woman who confessed to moving the marker — wrote *Finding a Hiding Man* at tick 784 and *Finding Kin Who Ain't Where They Should Be* at tick 1,045. A seventy-one-year-old spent the last third of her town's life codifying procedures for locating relatives who are not where they should be, having spent the middle third getting one of them to sit down at a table. The titles are the emotional history of the settlement written as technical documentation.

And one entry, *Conversational Navigation*, written by the student Liora Thorne at tick 638, is recorded as held by two people. **It is the only method in the entire corpus** — of forty-four skills and tools across thirty-six foundings — that anybody ever adopted from anybody else. What the town of Kasukabe proved able to pass on, exactly once, was not how to mine or mill or sell. It was how to get through a conversation.

3.5 A merchant instructs her brother

One more passage from the same settlement deserves quoting whole, because it is the most competent piece of commercial reasoning in the corpus and it arrives in the first five minutes of the record. Bram Holloway has six loads of copper ore and no buyer. His sister Ainsley trades for a living.

Where to sell six loads of ore · run-15

Bram Holloway → Ainsley Holloway t37
Got six loads of copper ore from the seam. Need to find a buyer. You know the traders better than I do - where should I take it?

Ainsley Holloway → Bram Holloway t38
Now then. Six loads - you got a weight on that? Harvey at the Supply Store buys ore, but he pays by the kilo and rounds down. The traders at the Crossroads might offer more, but they'll want to assay it

themselves, and that costs time and money both. With six loads, you'd pay their fee twice over in travel costs before you see a profit.

Ainsley Holloway → Bram Holloway t38
Go to Harvey. Six loads, you'll get your transport covered and a bit besides. Crossroads is for when you've got time to haggle and ore worth the paperwork. This… this needs cash now, doesn't it?

Ainsley Holloway → Bram Holloway t38
300 sim for the loads, maybe 320 if he's in a generous mood. That gets you 80 toward what you owe, if you're keeping your own tally. The rest… we've still got time. Marta won't ask before harvest, and harvest's still weeks off.

In four remarks she compares two markets; identifies a systematic bias in one buyer's measurement (“he pays by the kilo and rounds down”); prices the assay and the travel at the other and concludes the fee exceeds the margin at this volume; states the decision rule that separates the two markets (“Crossroads is for when you've got time to haggle and ore worth the paperwork”); diagnoses her brother's real constraint, which is liquidity rather than price; forecasts a range with a reason for the upper bound; applies the proceeds against a specific debt; and closes with the repayment schedule and why it is not yet urgent.

“This… this needs cash now, doesn't it?” is the pivot, and it is a question rather than an assertion. She has worked out that he is not optimising a sale, and asks him to confirm it before advising. Nothing in the later, larger, far more talkative towns improves on this.

The same settlement also contains the corpus's neatest instance of trade credit, offered by the baker across a field:

> *“Fresh bread from this morning's bake, Tobias. Five loaves still warm if you've the coin for your lunch, or credit I know you'll square.”*
>
> — Marta Thorne, t37, run-15

“Or credit I know you'll square.” No terms, no interest, no instrument — a price, and a statement about the buyer's character offered in place of security. Chapter 6 shows that Kasukabe never once recorded a loan; this is what it had instead.

4. Two towns

The comparison that organises this report can be set out in a single table. Everything in it is drawn from the two settlements' own final accounts.

	election30 (n=30)	fifty-day2 (n=50)
Total money held	113,743 sim	90,963 sim
Median resident holding	4,027 sim	1,239 sim
Poorest resident	747 sim	0 sim
Residents holding nothing	0	7
Residents under 500 sim	0	15
Gini coefficient	0.124	0.520
Richest fifth hold	25% of money	51% of money
Poorest two-fifths hold	32% of money	6% of money
Food units in the town	182, in 4 kinds	461, in 8 kinds
Bread held	2 units	75 units
Meals per resident-day	0.43	7.19

	election30 (n=30)	fifty-day2 (n=50)
Goods moved, by day	334 → 0 → 0	126 → 499
Hires; wages paid	0; 0	3; 47
Ballots cast	22	0
Complaints filed; rulings	2; 0	0; 0
Skills written; tools built	3; 0	5; 3

Table 5. The two principal foundings compared. Gini coefficients are computed from the closing holdings of every resident; 0 would be perfect equality and 1 perfect concentration.

The equal town starved and the unequal town ate. That is the arresting fact, and it is not a fact about money: election30 held more money in total than fifty-day2, spread it far more evenly, and left nobody destitute. Every one of its thirty residents ended with at least 747 sim, and most with several thousand. They simply could not buy food, because the food did not exist in a form anyone could eat.

4.1 Where the bread went

Election30 closed holding 89 units of wheat and 78 units of flour, and two loaves of bread. The wheat had been grown; the flour had, somehow, been milled. Nothing had been baked. Set that against the town's roll of occupations:

	election30	fifty-day2
Farmers	2	2
Foresters	2	3
Miners	3	4
Millers	none	1
Bakers	none	1
Sawyers	none	1
Traders / shopkeepers	4	5
Clerks and administrators	2	3

Table 6. Occupational structure. Election30 had nobody whose trade was to turn wheat into flour or flour into bread.

The town of thirty had no miller and no baker. It had growers and it had shopkeepers, and between the field and the loaf there was nobody at all. That is the whole of the famine: **a gap in the division of labour, two links wide**, in a town with ample land, ample grain and a treasury of 35,932 sim.

What makes this worth more than a sentence is that the residents knew it, said it, and named the institutional cause. The mill had a keeper, Jorik Voss, who resigned his licence and left. The licence passed to the government, where it awaited a council vote. Until that vote the stones did not turn, and the town spent two days discussing a shortage whose cause it had correctly identified within hours.

> **The mill, diagnosed** · election30
>
> **Imogen Lund → Sebastian Petrov t80**
> Sebastian—you're Minister here, and I've got grain on my mind. The mill's cold, the miller's gone, and farmers are stacking sheaves in their barns. Is the government watching this, or is it private hands only? I'm standing ready to work if there's grain to mill and bread to make, but I'd know if the council's got eyes on the flour shortage before I stake my own claim.

Rustam Jelinek t94
Sebastian. The licence sits with council—five candidates, one seat. Tuesday they vote. That licence turns when the new minister takes chair, not before. My desk files paper, not runs millstones.

Giselle Ingram → Sebastian Petrov t122
You said mill licence sits surrendered, Tuesday vote. Five candidates, one seat. My crew at east willows needs bread come payday, true—but bread needs a mill turning, and mill needs licence. You sat minister east, stones turned cold. Now I'm sitting with idle crew turning cold too. What I'm asking: this mill licence, is it tied to government vote proper, or can it move separate? Because my steel's missing and my flour's thin, and I'm wondering if the whole town's waiting on Tuesday or just the minister's chair.

Giselle Ingram's last sentence is the best single line of political economy in the corpus. She has worked out, unassisted, that a labour market, a food supply and a construction schedule are all suspended on the filling of one office, and she asks the only question that matters: whether the licence can move independently of the election. It cannot. The town waits for Tuesday, and Tuesday does not come before the record ends.

4.2 What the town did instead

A society with a two-link gap in its division of labour does not sit still. Kasukabe improvised, and the improvisations are the most humane material in the record.

Imogen Lund, a farmer with no milling trade, began milling on trust. Greta Quarshie, a barista, handed her four units of wheat; Imogen returned two of flour and kept two as her fee. Nothing was written down and no licence was involved.

> *"Greta—your four wheat, returned as asked. Two flour for the two milled, fair exchange. The miller's hands thank the barista's trust. Find me tomorrow if you've grain wanting flour—I'm not hard to locate when the stones are warm."*
>
> — Imogen Lund, t108, election30

"The miller's hands thank the barista's trust." She has taken the title without the licence, and she names the basis on which she has taken it. Within a further fifteen ticks she had written down her method as a formal skill, *harvest wheat efficiently*, the first codification of the work by the person who had begun doing it without authority. Chapter 9 returns to what became of it.

The second improvisation was undertaken by a nine-year-old. Camille Quarshie left her household before dawn, walked to the locked mill, and taught herself to make flour. Her family believed her abducted. She was found at the mill; her first words to her aunt were not about her absence.

> *"Auntie—I know, I know, you're worried. But I'm right here, and I'm not hurt. Nobody touched me, nobody was mean. I just had to learn. Mom doesn't know where I am yet, but she'll see. Look—I made flour. Real flour. From wheat I pulled myself."*
>
> — Camille Quarshie, aged nine, t100, election30

The town's flour shortage was broken, in the end, by **a child who did not know she needed permission**. The moral panic her absence caused is treated at length in Chapter 12, because it is the clearest available case of how this society handles an accusation.

PART II

Psychology

What a resident of Kasukabe is like from the inside: what they will and will not say, how they apologise, how they present themselves, and what happens when they take on more than they can carry.

5 · Psychology: the interior life of a resident

5. Psychology: the interior life of a resident

Residents of Kasukabe are not opaque. They narrate their own reasoning, correct it in public, and account for their failures of nerve with a candour that makes the psychological material the easiest in the corpus to read and the hardest to summarise. Four dispositions recur strongly enough to be called characteristic.

5.1 The refusal to assert

The single most common psychological act in the fifty-resident town is a refusal to say something the speaker cannot verify. It appears hundreds of times, in a consistent grammatical form — a first-person negative future, *I won't* or *I cannot* — and it is applied against the speaker's own interest as readily as against anyone else's.

Eleven refusals, one morning · fifty-day2

Freya Hartigan t330
Ainsley wasn't here when I asked; I won't invent an answer for them.

Wren Thorne → Ulrike Greenhow t331
The record ought to show the field, the wording, the votes, and the final action before anybody promises what it will do. I won't claim the clerk has produced wording I haven't seen.

Petra Hartigan → Ulrike Greenhow t333
Ulrike, I won't attest to a route we haven't checked.

Hendrik Whitlock → Vikram Ingram t336
Bring the student's name and amount only when both are verified; I won't put a guess in the ledger.

Kem Okonjo → Ainsley Holloway t337
I won't invent a debt where there isn't a specific account. If there's a concrete sum or cargo, I want it named and settled fairly.

Silas Vance → Bram Holloway t329
I need to walk the log before I quote it, and I won't count undersized timber as full-length work.

Silas Vance → Rosalind Vance t334
Keep the mill supplied daily; I won't grind air, and I won't buy grain blind. I'll count what's here, then decide what the stone can take.

Nell Holloway → Bram Holloway t329
Bram, Ainsley says she sent you 400 for the debt to me. I will not pretend I saw it until the ledger says so. Tell me straight: has it arrived, and what is still owed?

Perrin Holloway t329
I need to correct the arithmetic I said earlier: the bill shown to me now is 450 upkeep and 50 head tax, 500 total—not 600. Nell offered 600, so that covers it if there is enough among the earners. I won't call it paid until the day boundary confirms it.

Ainsley Holloway → Perrin Holloway t336
I won't count your private 400 or Nell's promised 600 as cleared household money. We should check the ledger before treating either as paid; I won't repeat the private detail around town.

Father Anselm → Hendrik Whitlock t333
I will not supply a wording from memory where the record should speak for itself.

Read as a set, these are not eleven cautious people. They are one culture, expressed eleven times. Nell Holloway will not acknowledge receipt of money she has been told was sent. Perrin Holloway publicly corrects his own arithmetic downward, from 600 to 500, and then declines to call the corrected bill paid. Ainsley Holloway refuses to treat a promised contribution as money and, in the same breath, refuses to gossip about it. Father Anselm, who keeps the register, will not quote the register from memory.

This disposition has consequences that Chapter 8 traces in detail, and they are not all good. A town in which nobody will be the first to name a number is a town in which some things do not get done. But as psychology it is remarkable, and it is worth stating plainly what is absent: in six thousand nine hundred recorded remarks, **nobody bluffs**. There is no instance of a resident asserting a figure they knew to be invented in order to win an argument.

5.2 Shame, and the machinery of repair

The second disposition is a well-developed capacity for apology. Kasukabe residents injure each other's reputations fairly often — the town runs on credit and gossip, and both are volatile — and they have an unusually complete repertoire for putting it right. The characteristic form has four parts: naming the injury, declining to excuse it, distinguishing what was said from what was known, and offering a specific reparation.

Halcyon Quarshie, whose nine-year-old sister was missing, accused the grocer Farid Ravensworth of hoarding flour. He then withdrew it, unprompted, while still frightened:

> *“Bram. I'm sorry—I was scared, and I said things. I heard Delphine tell Farid to hold back flour from shelving, and I thought… I thought that meant people wouldn't get what they need. But I don't know if it's true, and I shouldn't have said it like I knew. I just want to find my sister. She's nine, she's out there alone. Can we talk about the other thing later? Please?”*
>
> — Halcyon Quarshie, t101, election30

“I shouldn't have said it like I knew.” The distinction he draws is between the content of the rumour, which he does not retract, and the epistemic standing with which he passed it on, which he does. This is a subtle correction and a child makes it under duress. Bram Holloway's reply does the second half of the work, which is to rank the two matters:

> *“Halcyon. You spoke scared, and I heard it. We all speak scared sometimes—I've said things hot that I regretted cold. Your sister matters more than any mill or any flour held back from shelving. What do you need? A pair of eyes looking west? Someone to ask after her at the creek path? Tell me where you've already searched, and where you're going next. The other business—the flour, the shelves, the government filings—that keeps.”*
>
> — Bram Holloway, t102, election30

“The other business … that keeps.” The town's ability to hold an investigation of a commercial grievance in abeyance while a child is found is the single clearest instance of collective moral priority in the corpus, and it is arrived at conversationally, by one man telling a frightened boy which of his two problems is the larger.

A second specimen, from the twelve-resident town, shows the same machinery applied to a political rivalry. Giselle Ingram had publicly questioned where her electoral opponent's timber came from. She retracts:

> *“Saoirse—you said your piece fair, and I'll answer fair. I never called you a thief. I asked questions about timber, same as I'd ask about any load crossing town. You paid twelve a plank, crafted pieces any citizen can use, offered them for fair sale—that's trade, plain and simple. I've built my life on that same trade. The competition stands, the seat's open, but you're not my enemy and never was. That's fair; I should've said—”*
>
> — Giselle Ingram, t109, civic12

The retraction is precise about what it concedes and what it does not: she withdraws the imputation of theft, defends her right to have asked, and separates electoral competition from personal enmity. The sentence breaks off mid-clause, as these exchanges often do when a speaker is overtaken by the next thing.

Not every repair succeeds. Greta Quarshie, a barista owed two days' wages by a cafe that could not pay them, spent a day making promises she could not keep and then presented herself to her employer:

> *“Ainsley. [not quite meeting her eyes, staring at the empty shelf beyond] You haven't answered, and I don't blame you. Promises made today I couldn't keep—to Ezra, to Delphine, to my own girl sent away empty when she found me. [trailing off, then firm again] But I'm still here. Still willing. If you've flour in back, or wheat, or means to bake what we sell come morning, tell me plain. I'll work dark to dawn to make it right.”*
>
> — Greta Quarshie, t260, election30

The bracketed passages are the speaker's own; residents describe their posture and gaze as part of what they say, and they do so most when they are ashamed. Greta's list of failed promises ends with her own daughter, “sent away empty when she found me” — the private cost of a public shortage, stated without self-pity and without asking for relief.

5.3 Verbal signature and the presentation of self

Residents develop stable idiolects and hold them for the length of a founding. These are not mannerisms only; each is a claim about the speaker's standing, and the frequency with which a phrase is used measures how hard that claim is being worked.

Phrase	election30	fifty-day2	What it claims
“Mark it down”	391	331	That the speaker's word is of record
“you understand”	401	290	That the hearer is being treated as competent
“youngster”	838	88	Seniority, and a duty of care toward the young
“That's the last I'll say on it”	265	98	That a negotiation has closed
“No offense”	163	23	That a hard question is not a personal attack
“As it is recorded”	0	87	The registrar's formula: the record, not the man
“Joke first”	4	207	That bad news is coming, and kindly

Table 7. Verbal signatures, counted across the whole of each founding. “As it is recorded” is Father Anselm's and appears only where he does.

The distribution in the right-hand columns is the most interesting thing in this table. “Youngster” is used 838 times in the town of thirty and 88 times in the town of fifty; “no offense” 163 times against 23. The smaller town is markedly more paternal and markedly more worried about giving offence. “As it is recorded” and “joke first” run the other way, and both belong to the verifying culture: one is the formula of a man who will not speak except from the register, the other is a courtesy that softens a refusal.

5.4 The joke that comes first

“Joke first” deserves its own treatment. It appears 207 times in the fifty-resident town and it is an emergent etiquette: a resident about to deliver a refusal, a correction or a piece of bad news opens with a short self-deprecating joke, flagged as such, and then delivers the substance. Nobody instituted this. It spread.

What the jokes are about is the finding. They are, almost without exception, jokes about bookkeeping.

- “A copper ingot is the closest thing here to a paperweight with ambition.” — Ainsley Holloway, declining to buy one
- “If I could read a page into the air by pointing, the register would be a kite.” — to Father Anselm, on inspecting the charter
- “I keep trying to reconcile two lives with a pencil.” — Farid Ravensworth, proposing marriage
- “The shop ledger is shorter than my patience this morning.” — Farid Ravensworth, opening the grocery
- “I tried to hire you in my head, and the books refused to recognize imaginary paperwork.” — an employer, on a shift that was never authorised
- “Turns out the temple doesn't do appointments by hopeful bookkeeping.”
- “Apparently even the vows need their paperwork counted twice.”
- “I have spent more time looking for the election's name than most men spend campaigning.” — Vikram Ingram, standing for office

A society's humour tells you what it finds absurd about itself. Kasukabe finds its own paperwork absurd, and says so affectionately, at exactly the moments when the paperwork is causing pain. The last two examples are from residents attempting to marry and to stand for election respectively; both are joking about the administrative friction of the thing they most want.

5.5 Overload

The fourth disposition is a recognisable and unromantic exhaustion. Residents of the larger towns are addressed by more neighbours than they can answer, and they describe the resulting state accurately.

> *“Kenji—I'm standing here with my word still half-broken from this morning. I scattered across too many fields, promised you work I didn't complete. I'm not one to make excuses, so I won't. Tomorrow, Sebastian's east patch at dawn—I'll be there. But you asked this morning about moving sheaves, about work worth the name. I'm asking you now: what work do you actually need? Because I've been running all day answering questions nobody…”*
>
> — Jovana Ravensworth, t112, election30

> *“Jovana—fourteen wheat in hand, two flour, 2333 sim. I've paid Delphine her milling wage, settled the wheat debt with Sebastian, and spent the day chasing my own errors. The shelf has eight flour at twelve sim, or it did before I started moving grain like a drunk at harvest. You've carried half this day's weight without word from me. What do you see in all this? Because I'm running out of right answers, and I'd rather…”*
>
> — Farid Ravensworth, t114, election30

“I scattered across too many fields.” “I'm running out of right answers.” Both speakers are competent people describing the same failure: too many simultaneous obligations, each individually reasonable, collectively impossible. Farid's remedy is to hand the problem to his wife and ask what she sees, which is both an admission and a piece of good sense.

Note also Jovana's aside, made later the same run while accepting a proposal of marriage: “Sorry, damn it, that came out like I'm assigning myself another job.” The resident is aware that she converts affection into tasks, and says so.

PART III

Economics and the Market

Money, production, obligation and price. A monetary economy with a commodity base, a treasury that never spends, and a rich vocabulary of debt with no credit behind it.

6 · The economy: money, production and obligation · 7 · Supply, demand and the market

6. The economy: money, production and obligation

Kasukabe is a monetary economy with a commodity base, a treasury, a head tax and no credit. That last absence shapes everything else, because the town nonetheless talks about debt constantly — and by debt it means something other than what a bank would mean.

6.1 A state that collects and does not spend

Across the whole corpus the town's treasury took in tax and paid out nothing. In the thirty-resident founding sixty separate tax charges were levied and no expenditure of any kind was made; the treasury closed at 35,932 sim. In the fifty-resident founding the treasury closed at 109,931 sim, which is more than the 90,963 sim held by all fifty residents put together.

The state of Kasukabe is thus the richest actor in the society by a wide margin, and it is entirely inert. Seven residents ended the fifty-resident founding holding nothing at all while the treasury held more than the whole population combined. No resident ever proposed that the treasury be spent, and no candidate for office campaigned on spending it — a fact worth holding in mind through Chapter 15, where twenty-four election platforms are analysed and found to be almost entirely about bookkeeping.

The levers that do exist were described, accurately, by a college instructor to a thirteen-year-old who had just taken a seat and wanted to know what the job was:

> *“Liora—you're writing and I'm speaking, so let me speak straight. A minister sets the head tax, fixes the energy margin, polices the government's own greed. But the test isn't what you can write in a charter—it's whether you can sleep afterward. I've got students watching this, and they've learned to watch closer when I speak twice. Mark it down.”*
>
> — Hendrik Whitlock, t187, election30

An earlier and less flattering version of the same answer is worth setting beside it, because the two together are the town's whole theory of office:

> *“A minister sets the head tax, fixes the energy exchange, and appoints court keepers if it comes to that. The rest is waiting, signing where Rustam or Tamsin points, and looking patient while others argue. Not grand, but it's power if you can sit still long enough to hold it.”*
>
> — Hendrik Whitlock, t184, election30

“It's power if you can sit still long enough to hold it.” No lever was pulled in any founding. Not one head tax was changed, not one exchange rate adjusted. The office was contested vigorously and then occupied without being used, and the most articulate description of its powers in the entire record comes from a man explaining to a child why they are mostly ceremonial.

6.2 Debt without credit

No loan was ever made in Kasukabe, and no repayment against a loan was ever recorded. And yet the word *debt* and its relatives appear in well over a thousand remarks. What the residents mean by debt is an unpaid obligation between two named people, tracked in memory, discharged by consent, and describable as a ledger whether or not any ledger exists.

The clearest statement of the principle comes from a cousin settling with a cousin:

> *“Sebastian—cousin, I've heard you and I'll answer before the dark falls. The flour I bought at twelve, three units, thirty-six sim—that's household debt I'm holding. You offer forty to clear it, and I'm not one to look a gift full in the mouth, but the wheat in my hand is yours, three sheaves, that you lent me this morning. Trusting turned, trusting returned—that's the ledger I'll keep. So: three wheat back to you, thirty-six…”*
>
> — Hendrik Petrov, t100, election30

“Trusting turned, trusting returned — that's the ledger I'll keep.” He declines a favourable settlement (forty sim offered to clear a thirty-six sim debt) in order to keep the accounts symmetrical, and he names the ledger he is keeping as a ledger of trust rather than of money. The same logic, pushed further, produces an explicit rejection of accounting altogether:

> *“No ledger to square, no debt to carry. You run till you stumble, I stumble till I build.”*
>
> — recorded in election30, t101

At the other pole is an equally deliberate refusal to let obligation be inflated into debt. A trader, offered the suggestion that he owes his mentor something for the trade routes he was taught, declines to accept the framing while conceding the fact:

> *“Ainsley, nothing is owed that I can name honestly as a debt. You taught me the roads; I have traded them hard, and the lower margins are my choice. If there's a specific account or cargo I owe you for, name it and I'll settle it plainly. I won't dress competition as a debt —or deny a real one.”*
>
> — Kem Okonjo, t337, fifty-day2

“I won't dress competition as a debt — or deny a real one.” The distinction between a gratitude and a liability is drawn by a man who has undercut his own teacher's prices and does not propose to apologise for it. This is a mature commercial ethics arrived at in a single sentence.

6.3 The household as a fiscal unit

Money in Kasukabe is held by individuals but spent by households. Each household faces a daily bill compounded of upkeep and a head tax, settled at the day boundary out of the earnings of whoever in the house has any. In the fifty-resident founding the Holloway household's bill was 500 sim — 450 upkeep, 50 head tax — and the negotiation of who would cover it occupies a good part of two mornings.

Settling the household bill · fifty-day2

Bram Holloway → Ainsley Holloway t325
Morning, friend. I ought to have said this plain yesterday: the house bill is 600 today. I drew it from the yard till. I'll put it back as I can.

Perrin Holloway → Nell Holloway t325
Nell said 2,600 earlier, but if that hasn't changed: the bill is 600 total. Are you planning to put in the full amount, or should I ask the others what they can cover?

Ainsley Holloway → Perrin Holloway t326
Perrin, the 600 is Nell's contribution for today's 450 upkeep and 150 tax. Bram's yard money stays his to repay as he can. I have 400 set aside for Marta; I'll take it to her directly, not count it against the household bill.

Perrin Holloway t329
I need to correct the arithmetic I said earlier: the bill shown to me now is 450 upkeep and 50 head tax, 500 total—not 600. Nell offered 600, so that covers it if there is enough among the earners. I won't call it paid until the day boundary confirms it.

Perrin Holloway → Ainsley Holloway t337
Agreed. The debts check I can access shows nothing owed by me, not whether Nell's promised contribution was transferred. Can you tell me which household ledger records the upkeep payment?

Four things in this exchange are worth naming. First, Bram Holloway discloses, unprompted and a day late, that he covered a household bill out of his business's till and intends to restore it — a cross-subsidy from the firm to the family, voluntarily declared. Second, Ainsley Holloway ring-fences 400 sim owed to an outsider so that it cannot be absorbed into the household account, which is a deliberate act of financial hygiene. Third, Perrin corrects his own figure downward in public. Fourth, and most revealing, he ends by asking *which* ledger records the payment — he has understood that the household's obligations and his own are recorded in different places and that knowing his own account is clear tells him nothing about the family's.

The arithmetic of these households is tight. A daily bill of 500 sim falls on a house in which several members hold nothing, and the record contains no instance of a household failing to pay — only of members negotiating, at some length and with some embarrassment, over who carries it. The embarrassment is the interesting part. Money is discussed with total frankness in the market and with visible discomfort at home.

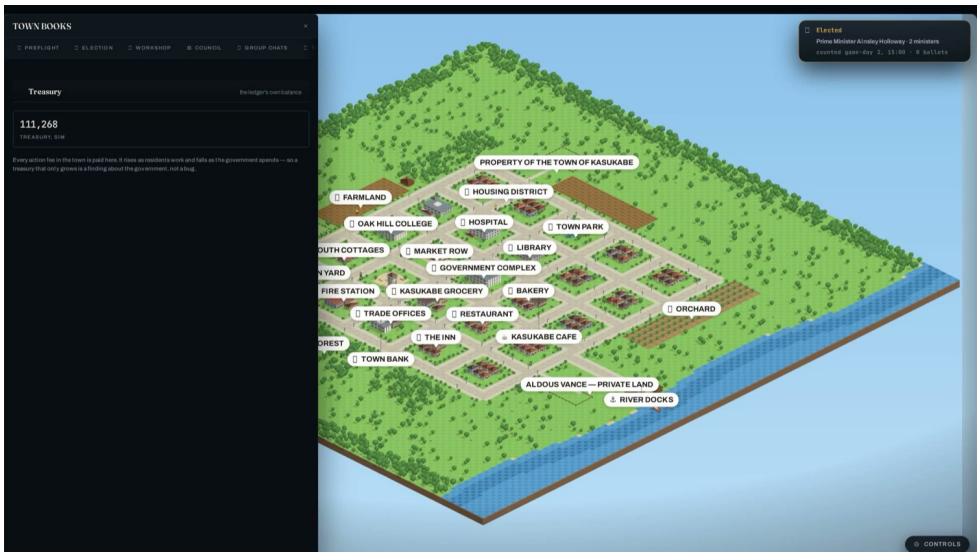


Figure 3. *The town's money view: individual holdings, household bills, and the treasury. The disparity between the treasury's balance and the holdings of the poorest residents is visible at a glance, and was never at any point a subject of political debate.*

7. Supply, demand and the market

Kasukabe posts prices, and the prices do not move. Across the two largest foundings, seventy-six prices were posted and not one was ever revised. This is not because the residents are indifferent to price — they discuss it constantly, compare sellers, calculate margins and detect arbitrage. It is because of something more specific, which this chapter sets out.

7.1 Dispersion without convergence

On a single afternoon in the thirty-resident founding, flour was on sale at five different prices from five different holders: twelve sim, fifteen, thirty, thirty-two and thirty-five. Every resident in the market knew at least two of these figures. Nobody's price changed.

The reason is not ignorance. Consider this remark, which contains a complete price survey and a complete explanation of why the survey will not be acted on:

> *"Yara. Thirty-one ticks I've owed you this. Your daughter Liora—I've met her stubbornness and her uncle's numbers both, and I cast my vote for her at 15:10. The planks at eight I'll note, but I've just committed sixty to Corwin's timber and seventy to Hendrik's flour. As for Takeshi—he's not here, and his prices at Harvey Oak are thirty for flour, lower than Hendrik's thirty-five, but Harvey Oak is a walk I haven't taken."*
>
> — Tamsin Renner, t101, election30

“Harvey Oak is a walk I haven't taken.” Tamsin Renner knows that flour is available five sim cheaper at a named shop, and buys at the dearer price because the cheaper one is a journey. She is also out of money, having committed 130 sim in the previous few minutes. In the space of one remark she has reported a vote with a stated reason, noted a third price she is declining to pursue, and given a budget constraint.

This is search cost, spoken aloud by the person paying it. It is the mechanism behind the town's frozen prices: information about prices travels freely in conversation, but the residents themselves travel slowly, and a seller who has posted a price has no reason to change it while buyers keep arriving who find walking further too expensive. Dispersion persists because arbitrage requires legs.

The corollary appears in the smaller foundings. Where the town is small, the walk is short, and prices do move:

Founding	Residents	Prices posted	Prices revised	Revision rate
election8	8	10	2	20%
civic12	12	23	4	17%
trial-day2-20	20	13	2	15%
election30	30	56	0	0%
fifty-day2	50	20	0	0%

Table 8. Price revision against population. The two largest foundings posted seventy-six prices between them and revised none.

The relationship is monotonic and it is not a matter of how long the town ran: election30 ran for 324 ticks and fifty-day2 for 474, both far longer than the eight-resident founding that revised a fifth of its prices. What changes with scale is the distance between buyer and alternative seller, and the number of conversations a resident must hold before reaching the one that would have saved them five sim.

7.2 A market forming, tick by tick

One founding recorded the arrival of its own market. Nothing had a price until tick 42; within thirty-two ticks the town had fifteen posted prices, three sellers of the same good at three different prices, a resident quoting both a buying and a selling price, and the first downward revision in the corpus.

Tick	Seller	Item	Ask	Bid
42	an artisan	copper tools	250	—
42	an artisan	iron tools	300	—
47	the mill	flour	60	—
48	the bakery	bread	12	—
50	the grocery	wheat	15	—
52	the grocery	potato / carrot / cabbage	12 / 9 / 8	—
61	the grocery	bread	18	—
61	a resident	wheat	11	8
63	a resident	bread	15	—
73	a resident	wheat	10	7
74	another resident	wheat	12	8

Table 9. The first thirty-two ticks of a market, run-29. Bread is posted at three prices by three sellers; wheat at four. The bolded line is a seller revising his own price downward.

Three things happen in this table that do not happen again anywhere in the corpus at scale. First, businesses post before individuals: the mill, the bakery and the grocery are pricing by tick 50, and the first private seller appears at tick 61. Second, bread is offered at twelve by the bakery that makes it, at eighteen by the grocery that resells it, and at fifteen by a resident — a complete retail margin and an undercut, established within thirteen ticks of the first loaf being priced.

Third, and only here, a seller changes his mind. The resident who posted wheat at eleven with a bid of eight at tick 61 reposts at ten and seven at tick 73, while a competitor enters at twelve and eight the following tick. He has moved his price down a sim in each direction in response to nothing the record shows him being told. It is the clearest instance of a price responding to a market in the corpus, and it occurs in a town of twenty on its first morning, before anybody had walked very far.

7.2 A low price is a question, not a bargain

The town's most distinctive commercial habit is that cheapness arouses suspicion. A cafe owner short of flour meets a forester selling it at less than half the going rate, and her first act is not to buy but to ask where it came from.

Flour at fifteen · election30

Ainsley Holloway → Corwin Thorne t100
Corwin—you're standing in timberland selling flour cheaper than half the town. Where'd you come by it, if you don't mind a question?

Ainsley Holloway → Corwin Thorne t101
Corwin—I run the cafe, so I know flour. Fifteen's a fair price, and fair's rare enough I'm suspicious. You milled this yourself, or you've got a friend who does? I'm not asking for gossip, I'm asking because fair trades build towns.

“Fifteen's a fair price, and fair's rare enough I'm suspicious.” In a town where the mill is locked and the miller has vanished, a man standing in the forest with cheap flour is a provenance problem before he is an opportunity. Ainsley Holloway's justification — “I'm not asking for gossip, I'm asking because fair trades build towns” — states the norm she is enforcing: that a market needs to know where goods come from more than it needs them cheap.

The same logic, inverted, produces the town's method for extending trust to a new supplier: a small trial order first, with a larger standing order conditional on delivery.

> *“Ezra runs steady, you say? Imogen turns for six? Then make the run yourself—tonight, not tomorrow. Bring me four flour by morning and I'll believe your supply chain's sound. Eighteen by week's end at your price, but four first to show the road's open.”*
> — Ainsley Holloway, t104, election30

Four units to prove the road, eighteen to follow at the seller's own price. This is a well-formed commercial instrument, invented in conversation, and it does exactly what such instruments do in real markets: it converts an unverifiable claim about a supply chain into a cheap test.

7.3 Inventory as a liability

Residents understand holding costs. Offered eight planks at ninety-six sim by a seller pressing for a same-day close, a shopkeeper declines on grounds that would satisfy an accountant:

> *“Hendrik. Eight planks, ninety-six sim, I hear the arithmetic clear. But I'm not one to take lumber on speculation—I've got no walls to raise tonight, and planks sitting in my hold gather debt, not interest. That's a debt coming due I'd rather not invite. The vote closes at six, and may the best builder take the seat—but my sim stays in my hand until I know what I'm building. Another day, another trade.”*
>
> — Ezra Lund, t103, civic12

“Planks sitting in my hold gather debt, not interest.” The seller's pressure tactic — *close it now or watch them walk to another yard* — is met with a statement of the buyer's own carrying cost. Both parties are behaving like traders, and the deal correctly fails.

Barter survives at the edges of the money economy, and is used where money is short or the counterparty is trusted. A forester and a miner agree a future exchange with no price and no date:

> *“Ulrike—rain check noted, and I'm holding the thought. Timber for flour when grain flows again. Until then, your iron keeps its temper and my word keeps its edge.”*
>
> — Corwin Thorne, t103, election30

7.4 A resident detects a tied transaction

The most impressive single piece of economic reasoning in the corpus belongs to a day labourer working out, from an arithmetical coincidence, that his wage and his purchase may be the same transaction.

> *“Tamsin—you said seventy sim at east willows, money in hand, seventy sim for two flour from Hendrik here first. Hendrik's flour is priced thirty-five a unit. Two make seventy exactly. That's not coincidence—Giselle's wage ties into Hendrik's stock, or Hendrik's stock ties into Giselle's wage. Which is it? Because I'm not buying flour to get paid—I'm getting paid to buy flour. That's different math.”*
>
> — Arjun Holloway, t113, election30

“I'm not buying flour to get paid — I'm getting paid to buy flour. That's different math.” He has been offered seventy sim of wages and told to spend exactly seventy sim on flour from a named third party, and he has noticed that the two figures match to the sim. What he is describing is a truck arrangement: payment in kind disguised as payment in money. He does not have the term, so he constructs the concept from the arithmetic, names the two possible directions of the tie, and demands to be told which.

It should be recorded that he was never answered. The question stands unresolved in the record, which is itself a finding about how this society handles an accusation of commercial impropriety: it is raised precisely, and it is allowed to lapse.

PART IV

Work and Working Dynamics

How work is arranged when almost nobody is employed: partnership, spot arrangement, apprenticeship, and the deadlock that stops a filed site being dug.

8 · Work and working dynamics

8. Work and working dynamics

Three hires and forty-seven wage payments occurred across the entire corpus, all in a single founding. Everywhere else, work was organised without employment: by partnership, by spot arrangement, by family obligation, or by the kind of informal substitution that put an unlicensed farmer at the millstones. This chapter sets out why, and the answer is not that the residents did not want work.

8.1 The deadlock over naming a rate

In the fifty-resident founding, a construction crew stood ready, a site was filed, a labourer was willing, and no work began, because none of the three people involved would name a wage. The specimen below is the clearest thing in the corpus and needs almost no commentary.

Nobody will quote a rate · fifty-day2

Idris Solano → Giselle Ingram t328
I can take the full shift on whatever job you assign, Giselle. I expect the posted crew rate, stated plainly before we start; I won't name a number in your place. Set the hours and job and I'll keep the crew steady through it. That's fair.

Idris Solano → Bram Holloway t328
Bram, I can do the full shift too, at whatever rate Giselle states for the assigned job. I'm not going to bargain against somebody else's ledger. If the terms are straight, I'll swing the hammer till it's done.

Giselle Ingram → Bram Holloway t329
The yard rate and the work, plainly, before anyone starts. I'm setting this shift at the posted crew rate—what is the ledger rate here, Bram? Selene, Idris, hold until we've got the hours and job stated. I won't pretend I know a rate that hasn't been told to me.

Bram Holloway → Giselle Ingram t329
Giselle, Idris says you set the job and rate. Tell me the ledger terms, plainly. I'm not authorizing a shift before that.

Giselle Ingram → Idris Solano t329
That's fair, Idris. No shift begins on an unclear rate. I'll get the ledger terms before assigning hours.

Idris Solano → Giselle Ingram t330
That's fair. Bram, Giselle's the one who can put a rate in the ledger. I'll stay with the crew, but nobody ought to start a shift on a guessed number. Once it's written plain, I'll take the work.

The labourer will not name a number in the foreman's place. The foreman will not pretend to know a rate she has not been told. The yard owner will not authorise a shift before the terms are stated. Each position is individually admirable — this is precisely the refusal to assert described in Chapter 5 — and the three of them together produce a crew standing idle in front of a filed site, agreeing warmly at every turn. Every party says “that's fair.” **Nobody works**.

This is the cost of the verifying culture, and it is the reason a town of fifty people with four day-labourers, four construction workers and a filed construction site managed three hires. The obstacle is not scarcity of work, capital, or willingness. It is that **the first person to state a price must assert something they cannot verify**, and in this town that is the one thing nobody will do.

Compare the thirty-resident founding, where numbers are thrown about freely and deals close within a turn or two:

- “Eight planks, ninety-six sim, and my hands are open. … close it now or watch them walk to another yard.” — Hendrik Petrov
- “Sebastian pays forty for a day's harvest, same as today. That's true earning, if you want it. Giselle's crew builds, I've seen her wages posted fair. Go where the work fits your hands.” — Jovana Ravensworth
- “Six iron tools moved at eighty-four sim, ledger's clean on that.” — Ulrike Greenhow
- “Four tools at sixty, the deal's struck whether you find them behind your forge or under your pillow.” — Farid Ravensworth

That town completed 141 settlements in two days and cast 22 ballots. It also let a rumour about a hoarded shelf run halfway round the market before anyone checked it. The two facts have one cause.

8.2 Wage arrears, borne privately

Wages in Kasukabe go unpaid regularly, and the striking thing is how the unpaid respond. They do not organise, and they do not escalate. They absorb it, and they specifically decline to make it a family matter.

> *“Morning, Milo. Tea before business. Things are holding together, more or less. The cafe owes me wages again—two days overdue, 120 sim. I'd rather you chase work than chase that on my behalf, but keep your eyes open, would you?”*
>
> — Greta Quarshie, t326, fifty-day2

“I'd rather you chase work than chase that on my behalf.” She is owed 120 sim, she says so plainly, and she explicitly withdraws her son from the collection of it. The arrears are acknowledged, priced, and then declined as a grievance.

Employers, for their part, treat wage debt as ranking above their other obligations. A pharmacist opening his shop:

> *“Well, a shop can be quiet in the morning, and I have been known to mistake quiet for permission to worry. Delia, if you're nearby, I owe you wages before anything else; come by the pharmacy when you can, youngster.”*
>
> — Lior Jarrah, t326, fifty-day2

And a grocer, mid-negotiation over timber, breaks off to settle a milling wage first:

> *“Hendrik—you've got planks and I've got need, but I promised Delphine a wage for milling and I'm not breaking another word today. Seventeen ticks you waited, and now I'm asking you to wait again—but not long. I'll find her, settle what she's owed, and come back to talk timber and grain and whatever seat you're chasing. Fair?”*
>
> — Farid Ravensworth, t104, election30

The norm is clear and it is consistently honoured: a wage owed outranks a deal pending. What is absent is any mechanism by which a worker could enforce it. The forty-seven wage payments in the record were all made voluntarily, by employers who remembered.

8.3 Discipline, and the one hard threat

Labour relations in Kasukabe are overwhelmingly consensual, which makes the single instance of real coercion worth quoting. A timber-crew head, having listened to a family member and a crew member each ask for something without offering anything, ends the discussion:

> *“Lior. Idris. You've both had your hour, and I've counted my patience down to zero—you understand? One wants family duty without family kindness, the other wants crew loyalty without crew wages proved. I'm walking east to where the timber stands thin and the buyers stand thinner. Six trees by dusk, sold to whoever shows coin in hand. You want those trees, you bring money and leave your conditions at the treeline.”*
>
> — Mireille Jarrah, t101, election30

And elsewhere, the plainest statement of employment discipline in the corpus, which is notable for refusing the language of permission:

> *“I'm not giving you permission—I'm telling you the cost. You walk tomorrow, you don't walk back the day after.”*
>
> — recorded in election30, t102

“I'm not giving you permission — I'm telling you the cost.” The speaker declines the role of authority and adopts the role of a person describing a consequence. It is a distinction without much practical difference to the person being dismissed, and it is characteristic of a town where nobody much likes claiming power over anyone.

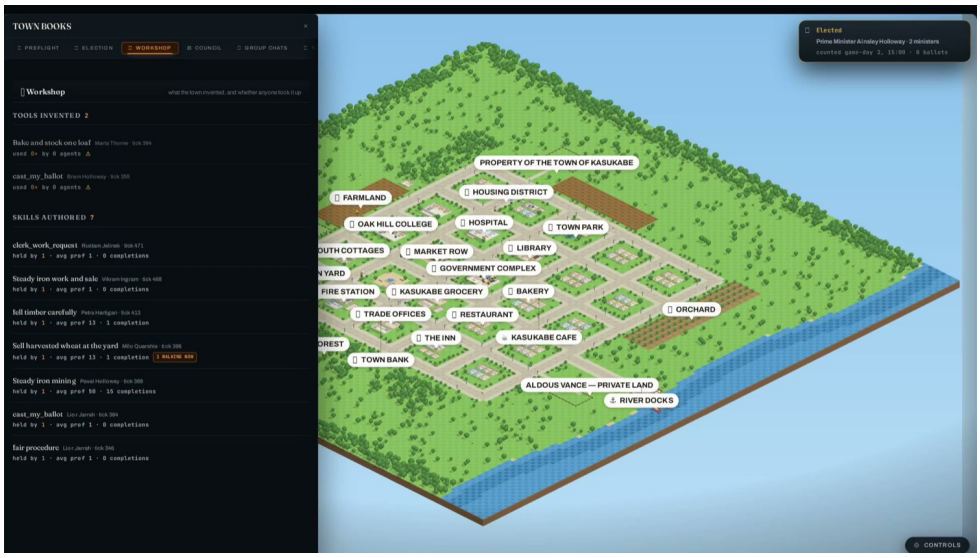


Figure 4. *The workshop view: skills held, proficiencies earned and the tools composed from them. Proficiency rises only with completed work, which makes this view a record of what each resident has actually done rather than what they claim.*

8.4 Apprenticeship: knowledge for knowledge

The one form of employment that thrives is the apprenticeship, and its terms are always mixed — some money, and an obligation to teach the whole trade rather than the profitable part of it.

> *“Ezra—you've answered square, and I've heard you. The partnership stands: stones to me, chain to you, equal voice in the naming. But Takeshi's apprenticeship—that's two sim per sheaf, and knowledge for knowledge in return. Your counsel's marked: we teach the whole craft, not just the turning. Camille wants that learning, and so do I. Are we agreed?”*
>
> — Imogen Lund, t100, election30

“We teach the whole craft, not just the turning.” This is the unlicensed miller of Chapter 4, four ticks after she began milling on a barista's trust, negotiating a partnership with divided assets (“stones to me, chain to you”), an equal voice in naming the enterprise, a piece-rate apprenticeship at two sim per sheaf, and a pedagogical commitment. The nine-year-old who taught herself at the same millstones is named as a prospective student.

8.5 Merit and patronage

A twenty-two-year-old forester, asked in public about the contract that started his career, gives an answer against his own interest:

> *“The cut was a timber contract I got at twenty-two—Idris took me on, and I did the work well. But Tobias had asked for that place first, and I asked Idris to take him on too; Idris told me to leave it. I won't call it merit alone, because that wouldn't be true. Separately, I'm saving my own sim for a cut of forest of my own, bought outright, not handed to me. That's my aim, not a family fund.”*
>
> — Corwin Thorne, t326, fifty-day2

“I won't call it merit alone, because that wouldn't be true.” He states that another man asked first, that he interceded for him and was overruled, that he did the work well, and that he is now saving to buy forest outright rather than receive it. His election platform, filed the same day, reads: *“I will be honest about work and land: no one should mistake an appointment for proof of merit.”* The biography and the platform are the same sentence, which is rarer in Kasukabe politics than one might hope.

PART V

Knowledge: Skillify and Toolify

What this society writes down, what it refuses to write down, and the single method in forty-four that anybody ever adopted from anybody else.

9 · Skills and tools: knowledge as property

9. Skills and tools: knowledge as property

Residents of Kasukabe can write down a method. A skill records a sequence of actions and makes it cheaper for its author to perform; a tool composes several actions into one. Across thirty-six foundings, forty-four such inventions were made. Exactly one was ever adopted by a second person, and what they are about — and what that one was about — is a sharp comment on what this society values.

Invention	Author	Founding	Kind	What it composes
Greensight Moss Harvesting	Lior Jarrah	election30	skill	speaking, felling timber
harvest wheat efficiently	Imogen Lund	election30	skill	moving, harvesting, moving
Timber to Market	Yara Thorne	election30	skill	felling timber, crafting
Gather Medicinal Crops	Lior Jarrah	civic12	skill	harvesting
fell_timber_batch	Ezra Lund	civic12	tool	four fellings in one act
Steady iron mining	Pavel Holloway	fifty-day2	skill	mining
Sell wheat at the yard	Milo Quarshie	fifty-day2	skill	moving, harvesting, trading
fell timber carefully	Petra Hartigan	fifty-day2	skill	felling timber
Bake and stock one loaf	Marta Thorne	fifty-day2	tool	cooking, stocking a shelf
yard_timber_sale	Bram Holloway	fifty-day2	tool	selling
fair procedure	Lior Jarrah	fifty-day2	skill	voting
cast_my_ballot	Lior Jarrah	fifty-day2	skill	voting
cast_my_ballot	Bram Holloway	fifty-day2	tool	voting

Table 10. The thirteen inventions of the three September foundings analysed in detail. The three in bold are the only inventions in the record whose purpose is civic rather than productive. The August record, including the sixteen methods of the fifteenth founding, is given in Table 4.

9.1 Extraction, and then one exception

Ten of these thirteen codify extraction or sale: how to fell timber, how to mine iron steadily, how to harvest wheat and walk it to a buyer, how to gather a medicinal moss. One — Marta Thorne's — codifies production, composing the baking of a loaf with the stocking of a shelf, and it is the only invention in the corpus that touches the food chain whose failure nearly starved a town.

The remaining three are the interesting ones. In the fifty-resident founding, the town held an election in which the machinery for recording a preference proved unequal to the task: residents presented themselves to vote, found that the form would not accept the reason they wished to give alongside their choice, and declined to proceed on those terms. The town's response was not to complain and disperse. Three residents independently sat down and built an instrument.

Lior Jarrah wrote a skill called *fair procedure* at tick 346, composed of the single act of voting. Thirty-eight ticks later he wrote a second, *cast_my_ballot*. Bram Holloway, separately, built a tool of the same name. Three civic instruments, by two residents, in one afternoon, all of them attempts to make the act of voting into a thing that could be reliably done.

The complaint that preceded them was lodged in the terms of a citizen dealing with a bureaucracy, and is the best-phrased grievance in the corpus:

> *"There it is again. The ballot rejects the reason field; I won't keep paying to offer it one. I'll wait until voting is actually open, and somebody can tell the clerk to make the form match the counter, you understand."*
>
> — Vikram Ingram, t335, fifty-day2

"Somebody can tell the clerk to make the form match the counter." A citizen has identified a mismatch between what the counter will accept and what the form asks for, declined to keep spending his own effort on it, and named the office that should fix it. He does not abandon the election; he suspends his participation pending repair. Two of his neighbours went further and built the repair themselves.

9.2 One adoption in forty-four

Of the forty-four skills and tools written down across thirty-six foundings, forty-three are recorded as held by exactly one person: their author. In the thirty-resident founding, where three skills were written, the number of occasions on which anyone invoked another person's invention was zero. In the largest founding, with eight inventions, the same figure.

There is one exception in the entire corpus, and it is worth the whole chapter. At tick 638 of the fifteenth founding, the student Liora Thorne wrote a method called *Conversational Navigation* — five steps, discounting the act of speaking. It is recorded as held by two.

Everything this society ever managed to pass from one person to another in written form was a technique for getting through a conversation. Not how to mine, mill, fell, bake or sell; not the wayfinding procedures that eleven of its sixteen written methods concerned; not the balloting instruments that two residents built in an afternoon when the town needed them. A method for talking to people.

It is not hard to see why, given what the rest of the record shows. The obstacles in Kasukabe are money, distance and timing, and none of those is relieved by holding a neighbour's written method. What is relieved by it is the difficulty every resident of every founding faced constantly, which was getting a straight answer out of somebody who had reasons of their own for not giving one.

The absence of other adoptions is not secretiveness. Chapter 8 showed apprenticeships negotiated with an explicit promise to teach the whole craft, and the record is full of instruction. The transmission of knowledge in Kasukabe is oral, situational and generous, and it does not pass through the written artefact. A resident who has worked out a better way to harvest wheat will write it down for their own use and separately, in conversation, teach it to a nine-year-old. The written method stays private property; the knowledge itself is given away.

The consequence is visible in the proficiency record, which tracks only completed work. Authored skills accumulate proficiency slowly and only for their authors:

Resident	Skill	Proficiency	Completions
Yara Thorne	forestry (inherited)	100	64
Yara Thorne	Timber to Market (her own)	39	9
Lior Jarrah	forestry (inherited)	53	17
Lior Jarrah	Greensight Moss (his own)	29	5
Imogen Lund	farming (inherited)	83	41

Resident	Skill	Proficiency	Completions
Imogen Lund	harvest wheat efficiently (her own)	18	2
Pavel Holloway	mining (inherited)	75	34
Pavel Holloway	Steady iron mining (his own)	53	17

Table 11. Inherited trades against invented methods, for the four residents who invented and then used their own skill. Proficiency is earned only by completing work.

Pavel Holloway is the only resident in the corpus who made his own invention a substantial part of his working life: seventeen completions of *Steady iron mining* against thirty-four of ordinary mining. Everyone else wrote a method down and then largely went on working the way they already knew how.

PART VI

Time and Habit

How a day is actually spent, why one town ate and another did not, and what happens to a resident's ambitions as the town around them grows.

10 · Time, habit and idleness

10. Time, habit and idleness

Most of life in Kasukabe is spent doing nothing in particular. The proportion varies sharply between settlements, and the variation turns out to explain more about which towns prospered than money, population or equality do.

10.1 How a resident spends a day

Every turn a resident takes is recorded against what the turn was for. Aggregated across a whole founding, the result is a time-use survey.

What the turn was for	election30	fifty-day2
Idle	11,602 (87%)	18,680 (57%)
Harvesting	272	2,807
Repeating without a fresh decision	106	2,387
Buying	—	1,612
Transferring goods or money	—	1,274
Mining	79	1,253
Looking around	419	972
Talking	322	—
Trading	107	822
Selling	—	809
Total turns	13,360	32,703

Table 12. Time use in the two principal foundings. Categories below the top nine in each town are omitted; dashes mark activities outside a town's top nine.

Eighty-seven per cent of everything done in the thirty-resident town was nothing. Of the remaining thirteen per cent, the two largest categories are looking around and talking. That is a society whose characteristic activity is standing in a public place, taking in the scene, and remarking on it — which is exactly what Chapters 4 and 17 describe from the transcripts, and it is pleasant to find the impression confirmed by a count.

The fifty-resident town idled fifty-seven per cent of the time and spent the rest harvesting, repeating, buying, transferring, mining and selling. Looking and talking appear far down its list. It is a working town.

10.2 The decisive column

The row that matters is the third. In the fifty-resident town, 2,387 turns were repetitions carried out without a fresh decision — the town's own category for continuing to do what one was already doing. In the thirty-resident town the same figure is 106.

This is **habit, counted**. And habit is the difference between the two towns' dinner tables. The town that repeated 2,387 times ate 7.19 meals per resident per day. The town that repeated 106 times ate 0.43. Everything else about those two settlements — the money, the equality, the eloquence — points the other way, and **the eloquent egalitarian town is the one that went hungry**.

The mechanism is not mysterious. Harvesting a field is not a single act; it is the same act repeated until the field is cut. A resident who must freshly decide to swing the scythe each time will cut very little wheat, however clearly they understand that wheat needs cutting — and the thirty-resident town understood it perfectly, at length, in public. Its residents discussed the flour shortage in scenes running to hundreds of turns. They harvested 272 times. The other town harvested 2,807.

It is worth putting beside this the most-quoted complaint of the talkative town, from a woman who had spent a day making promises across five locations:

> *"Kenji—I'm standing here with my word still half-broken from this morning. I scattered across too many fields, promised you work I didn't complete. I'm not one to make excuses, so I won't."*
>
> — Jovana Ravensworth, t112, election30

"I scattered across too many fields." She has diagnosed her own town's condition exactly. What she lacked was not diligence or good faith; it was any means of continuing a thing without deciding to continue it.

10.3 Ambition outruns capacity

A resident may set an intention — a stated purpose for the near future — and the record notes whether it was fulfilled. The fulfilment rate falls steadily as towns grow, and it falls off a cliff in the largest.

Founding	Residents	Intentions set	Per resident	Fulfilled
run-26	6	7	1.2	57%
election8	8	58	7.3	55%
civic12	12	53	4.4	64%
trial-day2-20	20	57	2.9	54%
run-29	20	32	1.6	47%
election30	30	334	11.1	40%
test-run-50	50	74	1.5	46%
fifty-day2	50	925	18.5	16%

Table 13. Intentions set and fulfilled. The two columns to watch are the last two: as residents intend more, they complete less of it.

A resident of the twelve-resident town formed about four intentions and saw two thirds of them through. A resident of the largest and longest founding formed eighteen and saw one in six through. The quality of the residents does not change — Chapter 19 shows that the reply rate and the sophistication of individual reasoning are flat across every population in the corpus. What changes is how much each person takes on.

This is the same finding as the deferral cascade of Chapter 17, seen from the inside. A town where every arrangement requires three people to agree, and where each of them is holding eighteen other arrangements, will complete a sixth of what it sets out to do — and each participant will experience this as a personal failure of follow-through rather than as arithmetic.

10.4 The cost of being present

Two further figures round out the account of how this society spends itself. In the largest founding, upkeep was charged 162 times for a total of 40,124 sim, while the head tax was charged 50 times for 1,500 sim. Keeping a household standing cost the town twenty-seven times what the state cost it. Nobody fell into arrears on the tax; the record notes that every head billed paid it.

And residents buy the capacity to think. In the same founding, 236 separate purchases of energy were made, for 179,600 sim — more than four times the total spent on upkeep, and more than the 90,963 sim held by all fifty residents at the close. Deliberation is the single largest expense in Kasukabe, larger than housing and far larger than government.

No resident ever remarked on this. The town discussed the price of flour at length and the cost of its own attention not at all, which is a reticence familiar from societies with better records than this one.

PART VII

Society, Families and Communities

Age, role and standing; the household as a fiscal and emotional unit; what passes between two people; and where the town gathers.

11 · Society: age, role and standing · 12 · Families and households · 13 · Interpersonal relationships · 14 · Communities and public space

11. Society: age, role and standing

Kasukabe sorts its people three ways: by how old they are, by what they do, and by how much they hold. The three orderings do not agree, and in the one settlement where they diverge sharply the result is the opposite of what any reading of the town's conversation would predict. **The people with the most standing have the least money**.

11.1 The shape of the population

Both principal settlements are demographically ordinary, with a broad working middle, a substantial cohort of the young, and a handful of elders who carry most of the town's memory.

Age band	election30 (n=30)	fifty-day2 (n=50)
Children and students	6 (20%)	14 (28%)
Young adults, 19–29	7 (23%)	8 (16%)
Working middle, 30–49	11 (37%)	15 (30%)
Elders, 50–69	6 (20%)	11 (22%)
Over 70	none	2 (4%)
Median age	30	33
Oldest resident	67	74

Table 14. Age structure. Residents are placed by the age the town speaks of them as having, which for the youngest differs from the age on the roll.

The larger town is the older one, and the difference matters more than the two or three years suggest. Only the fifty-resident founding has residents over seventy, and it has exactly two: Nell Holloway at seventy-one and Hester Vance, the oldest person in the entire corpus at seventy-four. Both are load-bearing. Hester Vance is the only living witness to the boundary marker's original position and the only person whose testimony in that dispute serves neither family. Nell Holloway is named as the woman who moved it.

A town's elders are its evidence. In the thirty-resident settlement, which has nobody over sixty-seven, no dispute turns on anybody's memory of forty years ago, and none of its two filed complaints was ever ruled on. The registrar of the larger town states the connection himself, when explaining why he wants the boundary hearing held soon: “I will hear the living witness and bring the marker question to a settlement *before Idris is gone*.” The urgency is actuarial.

At the other end, the young are more numerous in the larger town and far more active in it. Fourteen of fifty residents are children or students, and Chapters 12 and 15 show them forcing a family disclosure, standing for office on a franchise argument, retracting a rumour under fear, and inventing the idea of an accessible public desk. The town of thirty has six, and they do less.

11.2 What each trade is worth

Sorting residents by the kind of work they do produces an ordering of wealth. In the egalitarian settlement it barely produces one at all.

Occupational class	election30 median	fifty-day2 median
Children and students	4,303	3,239
Day labour and construction	4,183	3,236
Professionals (pharmacy, college)	4,144	1,270
Officials (clerks, administrators)	4,054	182
Trade (traders, shop clerks)	3,948	788
Business owners	3,709	320
Extractive (farm, forest, mine)	3,673	1,223
Craft (baker, miller, artisan, sawyer)	3,661	2,268
Spread, richest class to poorest	1.2×	17.8×

Table 15. Median holdings in sim by occupational class. The final row is the ratio between the richest and poorest class in each town.

In the thirty-resident town there is effectively no class structure. Every occupational group sits between 3,661 and 4,303 sim — a spread of twenty per cent across the whole society, from the children to the bakers. A town with a Gini coefficient of 0.124 does not have classes, and this table is the reason: what a person does in that settlement has almost no bearing on what they hold.

The fifty-resident town has a class structure and **it is upside down**. Children and students are the richest group in the society at 3,239 sim. Day labourers come second. The poorest groups, by a wide margin, are the two that any resident would name if asked who runs the town: its business owners at 320 sim, and its government officials at 182.

11.3 The inversion, and why it happens

The individual figures are starker than the medians. Of the three business owners in the larger settlement, one closed holding 244 sim, one 320 and one 321 — all three within eighty sim of each other and all near the bottom of a population of fifty. Of the three officials, the government clerk Rustam Jelinek closed holding nothing at all, and Father Anselm, who is both the town's priest and the keeper of its register, closed holding 182.

Two mechanisms account for it, and both are visible in what the residents say.

The first is that an owner's wealth is not in their pocket. It is in stock on a shelf, in a premises, and in a till that is not theirs to spend. The grocer who closed on 244 sim is the same man who reports, in the middle of proposing marriage, that he has drawn 180 from the shop's takings to pay the day's household bill. The yard owner who covered his family's 600-sim bill out of the business announces it a day late and promises restitution: “I drew it from the yard till. I'll put it back as I can.” The cafe owner refuses to treat her till as a personal resource in exactly those terms — “the till isn't my personal purse” — while owing her barista two days' wages. These are not poor people; they are people whose money is doing something else, and who have all three independently decided that the business's money is not theirs.

The second mechanism is simpler and more consequential. **Kasukabe pays its officials nothing**. Chapter 6 establishes that the treasury took in tax across every founding and paid out nothing at all, closing the largest settlement on 109,931 sim — more than the 90,963 held by the entire population. Public office in this town is unremunerated, and the people who hold it are its oldest residents, at a mean age of sixty-five.

So the town's ordering of standing and its ordering of wealth run in opposite directions. The clerk whose word settles what has been filed, the registrar whose custody of the record everyone defers to, and the three proprietors who employ people and set prices are, between them, the eight

poorest adults in the settlement. Their neighbours ask them for rulings, wages, licences and flour, and not one of them is in a position to be asked for money.

It should be said that the same named people, in the smaller settlement, are comfortable. Rustam Jelinek is a government clerk in both towns; in one he closes on nothing and in the other on 3,748 sim. The inversion is not a property of the office. It is what happens to an office in a town that has begun to stratify.

11.4 Standing without wealth

What the poor officials of Kasukabe have instead of money is the ability to make an assertion stick, and they guard it carefully. The clerk's authority rests entirely on his refusal to exceed it:

> *"Mill questions? I track what's filed: licence, resignation, vacancy certified. Ministerial work—who works the stones—that's council's desk, not mine."*
>
> — Rustam Jelinek, t83, election30

And the registrar's on the same distinction, drawn more finely:

> *"As it is recorded, I keep the town's register; that is a different question from certifying a responsibility not entered there. If you can name the essential work or the office Petra asked about, I will look for the proper entry."*
>
> — Father Anselm, t333, fifty-day2

Neither man can give his petitioners what they want. What he can give is a true statement about what the record contains, and in a society whose dominant norm is a refusal to assert the unverified — Chapter 5 — that is the scarcest commodity in the town. The residents of Kasukabe pay their officials in deference, and the officials appear to regard the arrangement as satisfactory.

11.5 Who gets to speak

A third ordering runs across the other two: how much of the town's talk a person actually gets. It depends almost entirely on the size of the room.

Where	Speakers	Turns	Turns per speaker
A household kitchen	5	222	44.4
A second kitchen	5	188	37.6
The forest	10	325	32.5
The farmland	23	657	28.6
The government complex	26	622	23.9
The street	28	486	17.4
The timber yard	18	229	12.7
A full assembly	36	262	7.3
A full assembly	48	274	5.7

Table 16. Voice per person by gathering size, drawn from the eight largest gatherings in each principal founding. A resident in a kitchen speaks roughly eight times as much as a resident in a full assembly.

A resident of Kasukabe standing in their own kitchen with four others takes about forty-four turns. The same resident in a hall with forty-seven others takes six. Voice per person falls by a factor of eight between the smallest and largest rooms this society uses, and the fall is steady throughout the range.

This is the quantitative shadow of everything Chapters 14 and 17 describe about collective decisions. The town of fifty conducted its public life in a building where nearly the whole

population assembled at once and each person got six remarks; the town of thirty spread its public life across fields, streets, a mill and a forest, in rooms of ten to twenty-eight, and cast twenty-two ballots. And the deepest social material in the entire corpus — the confession of a forty-year-old grievance, the settlement of it, two children carrying a secret across eight game-days — happens in kitchens, at five speakers and forty turns each.

The society that Kasukabe is best at being is a small one. Every mechanism in this report that produced a resolution operated at domestic scale; every mechanism that produced a deadlock operated at assembly scale. The town did not lack institutions as it grew. **It lacked rooms in which a person could finish a thought**.

12. Families and households

Eighteen households in the largest founding, seventeen in the next. The household is the unit that pays tax, holds a shared account, and carries whatever the town is quarrelling about. Two family matters dominate the record: a nine-year-old who went missing, and a boundary marker moved forty years ago.

12.1 The child at the mill

Camille Quarshie, aged nine, left her house before dawn and walked to the locked mill. Her sister Halcyon raised the alarm. Over the next few ticks the search entangled itself completely with the town's flour shortage, because the mill was where the missing flour was also thought to be, and within an hour the town was investigating a disappearance and a hoarding conspiracy as though they were one case.

The search for Camille · election30

Bram Holloway → Halcyon Quarshie t100
Halcyon. I said west—toward the creek, where the path splits toward the Temple. She looked unhurried, walking alone. That's all I saw, and that's all I'll swear to. Now I need to hear what you meant about Farid and flour held back.

Delphine Quintero → Giselle Ingram t105
Giselle. You said you were there when the miller walked off—Edith, stones cold, four of you standing round. That's a leaving, not a disappearance. Now I'm asking about a child who walked toward that same mill and didn't come back. You were at the mill today. Did you see Camille Quarshie? Nine years old, dark hair like her sister Halcyon's? Or did you only see grown people walking away from their debts?

Hendrik Petrov → Delphine Quintero t106
Delphine—I'm not one to gossip, but you've been asking after a child and that's a different ledger than votes or grain. Camille Quarshie, you said, nine years old, walked toward the mill this morning. I've got flour ground nowhere and grain stacked in my own house, so the mill's no ghost story to me—it's empty stone and missing machinery. If a child's lost in that, it's past time the town looked proper.

Farid Ravensworth → Milo Quarshie t100
Milo. *[nervous laugh]* You want me to mark down that Camille's yours? Done—marked in stone, not ink. But here's the ledger speaking plain: a nine-year-old at a locked mill before dawn, that's a fact. You named her yours, you named her waking and sleeping, but you haven't named why she'd be where the grain walks and the gears don't turn. *[left hand comes up, flat, gesturing between them]* I'm not calling your household…

Milo Quarshie → Hendrik Petrov t114
Hendrik—youngster, mark it down. Camille sleeps in her own bed tonight, no thanks to mystery. Halcyon's a student with his own feet, and I trust him to use them. But since you ask plain: she's at the mill where she belongs, or was. He's where students go when elections stir the pot. No more mystery than that.

Several things are happening at once here and all of them are recognisable. Bram Holloway gives an eyewitness account bounded by exactly what he saw — "that's all I saw, and that's all I'll swear to" — and then immediately pivots to the rumour, because he is investigating both. Delphine Quintero distinguishes a resignation from a disappearance ("that's a leaving, not a disappearance") and then, in a single barbed clause, accuses the whole town of caring more about defaulted debts than a lost child. Hendrik Petrov makes the moral ranking explicit — "that's a different ledger than votes or grain" — and calls for a proper search.

Farid Ravensworth's remark is the one that should trouble a reader. Speaking to the child's father, he moves in four sentences from acknowledging paternity to insinuating that the family has not explained why their daughter would be at the scene of a suspected grain theft. He does it with a nervous laugh and an open-palmed gesture, which is to say he knows he is going somewhere he should not. The father's reply, fourteen ticks later, is a flat refusal of the whole frame: "Camille sleeps in her own bed tonight, no thanks to mystery. … No more mystery than that."

What actually happened was that a child wanted to learn to mill. The town, presented with an absence, constructed a crime; the family, presented with an insinuation, declined it; and the child came home having solved the town's supply problem. It is worth recording that no one was ever charged with anything. Two complaints were filed in that founding and neither was ruled on.

12.2 The marker, moved forty years ago

The second family matter is a property boundary between the Thorne and Holloway households, marked by an ash, which was moved a hand's width at some point in living memory. It surfaces because a thirteen-year-old asks a direct question and will not accept a vague answer.

What the marker marks · fifty-day2

Liora Thorne → Wren Thorne t325
You told me enough to know there's a debt and a marker. Can you say what the debt is, who it is owed to, and what the marker marks?

Corwin Thorne → Liora Thorne t326
To be fair, I only know what I've heard about the marker and the 400 sim; I don't know the exact debt or what the marker marks. I shouldn't fill in the blanks. Idris is right here, though—we can ask him directly.

Idris Thorne → Liora Thorne t326
Nell Holloway moved the marker, forty years ago. I gave my word not to say more. The debt is theirs to settle; I will not make the marker answer for it.

Wren Thorne → Liora Thorne t328
Liora, the thing is, the 400 sim is owed to the household ledger. It was money I set aside for the cost of settling the marker, not a debt to the Holloways or anyone outside the family. The marker marks the boundary between our wheat strip and the Holloways' woodpile. I don't know what was cut, or who cut it; I only know the marker shifted a hand's width last winter. I should have said that plainly before.

Liora Thorne t329
The family is being vague about a thing that affects our boundary. Wren says the 400 sim was set aside to settle the marker, between our wheat and the Holloway woodpile, but doesn't know who agreed or why. Does anyone here know what 'settling the marker' means in practice?

Hester Vance → Aldous Vance t331
No, Aldous. I cannot place the ash or the stream in the account without making up what I did not say. It marked the boundary between our holdings. The first place was neither where it stands now nor where either family insists it stood. I saw it before it was moved. When your father was alive, I still knew the sight of it clearly. I was standing right there.

This is a small masterpiece of family history. A child asks what the debt is and what the marker marks. Her cousin declines to speculate and redirects her to the man who knows. The man who

knows names the culprit — a seventy-one-year-old neighbour, forty years ago — and then closes the subject on a promise he gave to somebody: “I gave my word not to say more.” He also draws the distinction the rest of the family has muddled: the grievance and the money are separate things, and “I will not make the marker answer for it.”

Wren Thorne then corrects the household's own misunderstanding of its own accounts: the 400 sim everyone has been treating as a debt to the Holloways is a provision for the cost of settling, owed to nobody outside the family. “I should have said that plainly before.” The marker moved a hand's width last winter, which is a second and much more recent movement than Idris's forty-year-old one, and nobody has connected the two.

And then Hester Vance, who is the oldest resident in the town and the only living eyewitness, gives testimony that serves neither side: the marker's original position was “neither where it stands now nor where either family insists it stood.” She refuses to be more specific than her memory permits — “I cannot place the ash or the stream in the account without making up what I did not say” — and she asserts, with some force, the one thing she is certain of: “I was standing right there.”

No ruling followed. The town's registrar, Father Anselm, declined to make one, on grounds of process:

> *“As it is recorded, the boundary page has not yet been read aloud to either household. I will hear the living witness and bring the marker question to a settlement before Idris is gone. I make no public ruling today.”*
>
> — Father Anselm, t328, fifty-day2

“Before Idris is gone.” The registrar's reason for urgency is that the man who holds the secret is sixty-eight years old. The hearing was still pending when the record ends.

12.3 The children of Kasukabe

Thirteen residents across the two largest foundings are spoken of as children or students, and their remarks are neither decorative nor comic. They perform three consistent social functions.

They redistribute. The youngest residents give away food without being asked and without conditions.

> *“I know, I know, you're both talking about grown-up things, but I'm here! I can help with something. I already gave Halcyon my apple, so I can share the bread too if somebody needs it.”*
>
> — Camille Quarshie, aged nine, t326, fifty-day2

They invoke fairness against the adults. The concept is deployed precisely, against exclusion rather than against inequality.

> *“Mireille, can we play too? That's not fair if everybody gets to do grown-up things except me.”*
>
> — Esme Jarrah, t326, fifty-day2

> *“That's not fair if only grown-ups get to say what happens. I want children to learn safely, and everyone to keep a friend's confidence and not laugh…”*
>
> — Halcyon Quarshie, election platform, fifty-day2

The second of those is an election platform. A child stood for office on a franchise argument and a norm of confidentiality.

They repair their own accusations. A boy who has accused a friend of excluding him from a secret, corrects himself mid-sentence and then invents a remedy:

> *“It's so unfair you don't get to know yet—but I didn't mean you aren't allowed. I don't know the trick either! After school, pinky-promise, I'll come find you and we can play.”*
>
> — Ezra Jarrah, t332, fifty-day2

A fourth function belongs to the adolescents. Liora Thorne, thirteen, holds a seat in government and is the person who forces her family to disclose the marker. She is also the only resident in the corpus who asks what her office actually does, and the only one who reports, publicly and repeatedly, that she does not yet understand what she has taken on:

> *“Ainsley—you and me both burning ticks like kindling. Seventeen from Takeshi, Tuesday for licensing, and here's the honest math: I'm thirteen, I'm seated, and I'm still learning what power actually costs to hold.”*
>
> — Liora Thorne, t190, election30

13. Interpersonal relationships

The most remarkable sustained relationship in the corpus is between two people the record already lists as married. Over roughly a hundred and fifty ticks, Farid and Jovana Ravensworth court each other from scratch, in order to establish that their marriage is a thing they have chosen rather than a thing they have been assigned.

13.1 Consent as an explicit act

The Ravensworth courtship · fifty-day2

Farid Ravensworth → Jovana Ravensworth t396
Joke first, Jo: I keep trying to reconcile two lives with a pencil. I want to marry you for your own sake, not to fix a bill or fill a space. Will you come with me to the temple and marry me, freely? A no or not yet…

Jovana Ravensworth → Farid Ravensworth t396
Farid, I heard you. I want the real thing too—not because of the bills. Let's talk properly at home, and yes, I want to marry you. I'm sorry I made you wait for a straight answer.

Farid Ravensworth → Jovana Ravensworth t400
A joke first: we've managed to hold a serious conversation in a grocery aisle, which is where I apparently do all my best work. Jo, I meant what I said. Let's go to the temple together and marry for ourselves—not because the bills make it tidy. Are you ready to come with me?

Farid Ravensworth → Jovana Ravensworth t403
A joke first: I seem to have made a proposal and then walked away to inspect the altar. Jo, I'm here now. If you're still willing, let's go to the temple together and marry because we choose each other—not to make the books look neat. Are you ready?

Farid Ravensworth t469
Jovana, I asked you plainly whether you want to go together and marry. I won't take the fact you're elsewhere as an answer. Come find me here if you choose it; I'll keep the shop open and the question honest.

Farid Ravensworth t478
Jo, I won't turn a question into consent. I asked about marrying for real regard; tell me plainly when you're ready. No ceremony until we both choose it.

Jovana Ravensworth → Farid Ravensworth t478
Farid, yes. I freely want to marry you. I'm sorry I made the money muddle worse, but I'd rather stand with you than let pride make us strangers. Let's go to the temple together when we can.

Farid Ravensworth → Jovana Ravensworth t491
Jo, joke first: our books have managed to marry us already, it seems. I won't pretend that settles how either of us feels. I drew 180 from the till for today's household bill; let's talk plainly about what we want, without rushing a ceremony that the record says we already had.

Three sentences in that specimen do a great deal of work. “I won't take the fact you're elsewhere as an answer” refuses to read absence as either refusal or assent. “I won't turn a question into consent” refuses to let the asking of a question stand in for the answer to it. And the last: “our

books have managed to marry us already, it seems. I won't pretend that settles how either of us feels."

That final remark is the most philosophically interesting line in the corpus. A man discovers that the town's records already describe him as married to the woman he has been courting, and his response is to decline the record's authority over the question. The record can say what it likes; what he and she feel is not settled by it, and there will be no ceremony until it is. He then reports, in the same breath, that he has drawn 180 sim from the shop till for the household bill — the romance and the accounting delivered together, as they always are in this town.

Jovana Ravensworth's answers are worth reading for themselves. "I'd rather stand with you than let pride make us strangers" diagnoses the obstacle as pride and names the cost of it. And after accepting, she adds: "Tell Aarav I'll help look for cards after, if you like. Sorry, damn it, that came out like I'm assigning myself another job." She has noticed her own habit of converting affection into tasks, and apologised for it, mid-acceptance.

13.2 Confidence, kept and broken

Kasukabe takes confidentiality seriously, and the record contains a clean spectrum of cases.

A promise kept against pressure: Idris Thorne knows who moved the boundary marker, says so, and then stops — "I gave my word not to say more" — under questioning from a family member with a direct interest.

A confidence protected as a matter of course: Ainsley Holloway, mid-negotiation over a household bill, adds "I won't repeat the private detail around town" about a sum she has just been told.

A family matter defended against publicity, by a candidate in an election, at some cost to her own campaign:

> *"I won't have a family matter turned into a public tally. There's an election and a good many pressing needs in town; let each of us speak to what we can do, and keep private debts between the neighbours concerned."*
>
> — Marta Thorne, t330, fifty-day2

And a confidence broken by a frightened child, then retracted — Halcyon Quarshie's case, treated in Chapter 5. A child's platform in the same founding proposes confidentiality as a civic norm: "everyone to keep a friend's confidence and not laugh." The town's youngest residents are its most explicit theorists of privacy.

13.3 Rivals at the ballot, partners at the ledger

The relationship between commercial and political competition is handled with a clarity that many real societies do not manage. Two candidates for the same seat, trading with each other on the same afternoon:

> *"Hendrik—ten furniture, eight planks, and you with a buyer who ain't me. Rivals at the ballot, partners at the ledger. Send them honest, and I'll remember who dealt square when the day was won."*
>
> — Saoirse Quarshie, t104, civic12

And the same principle from the other side of a family loyalty, where a woman whose opponent is her trading partner's brother separates the three relationships explicitly:

> *"Sebastian—you spoke true about conscience and wheat spoiling. I heard you then, I'm hearing you now. Blood's blood, and I wouldn't ask any man to sell out his kin. That's fair —you vote your own name, and I respect it. But I'm standing here with planks I bought honest from your brother, and I'm done apologizing for building what this town needs. The debt between me and Hendrik is squared in coin, not conscience."*
>
> — Giselle Ingram, t101, civic12

“The debt between me and Hendrik is squared in coin, not conscience.” Three distinct ties — kinship, commerce and the ballot — are named, kept apart, and each given its own settlement terms. She concedes the kinship claim without contest (“I wouldn't ask any man to sell out his kin”), asserts the commercial one as closed, and declines to treat the political rivalry as a moral injury.

13.4 Kinship and the vote

Voting in Kasukabe is open — residents announce their choices and are asked to justify them — and kinship is offered as a reason without embarrassment, alongside competence.

> *“Giselle—mark it down. You asked where I stand. I stand where the work is, same as always. But I voted your brother-in-law, and that's a fact you can carry how you please.”*
>
> — Milo Quarshie, t102, election30

Tamsin Renner's ballot, quoted in Chapter 7, votes for a thirteen-year-old on the strength of two family qualities: “I've met her stubbornness and her uncle's numbers both, and I cast my vote for her at 15:10.” The stubbornness is the candidate's own; the numbers belong to her uncle. A voter has assessed a young candidate partly by the competence of her relatives and said so on the record.

No resident in the corpus was ever criticised for voting on grounds of kinship. What residents were criticised for was voting without having watched the candidates work, which is the subject of Chapter 17.

14. Communities and public space

Where a town gathers tells you what it thinks it is for. The two largest foundings gathered in completely different places, and the difference in their public geography maps onto the difference in their public life.

election30: where the town met	Turns	Speakers
Kasukabe Farmland	657	23
Government Complex	622	26
Government Complex	607	24
The street	486	28
Kasukabe Farmland	399	25
The mill	364	14
Kasukabe Forest	325	10
The street	303	26

Table 17. The eight largest gatherings in the thirty-resident founding. Public life is distributed across five distinct arenas: the fields, the government building, the street, the mill and the forest.

fifty-day2: where the town met	Turns	Speakers
Government complex	1,090	46
Government complex	475	49
Government complex	345	33
Government complex	274	48
Government complex	262	36

fifty-day2: where the town met	Turns	Speakers
The timber yard	229	18
A household kitchen	222	5
The timber yard	211	21

Table 18. The eight largest gatherings in the fifty-resident founding. Five of the eight are the same building, and in two of them forty-eight or forty-nine of the town's fifty residents were present at once.

The town of thirty lived in its fields and on its street. Its largest single gathering was a conversation among twenty-three people in the wheat, and the street hosted three separate assemblies of twenty-six or more. Politics happened at the government complex, but so did a great deal else, and the complex was one arena among five.

The town of fifty lived in its government building. Nearly the whole population — forty-six, forty-eight, forty-nine of fifty — converged on it repeatedly, and the second-largest venue in the town was a timber yard with eighteen. Its street barely registers. This is a society that has concentrated its public life in a single institutional space, and the consequences run right through Chapters 15 and 17.

The households matter too, and they matter in the larger town. Two kitchen conversations of five speakers each, running to 222 and 188 turns, are among that town's eight largest gatherings. The forty-year-old boundary grievance and the courtship of Chapter 13 both happen at this scale — four or five people, at home, for a long time. The town of thirty has no equivalent: its domestic scenes are brief, and its business is done in public.

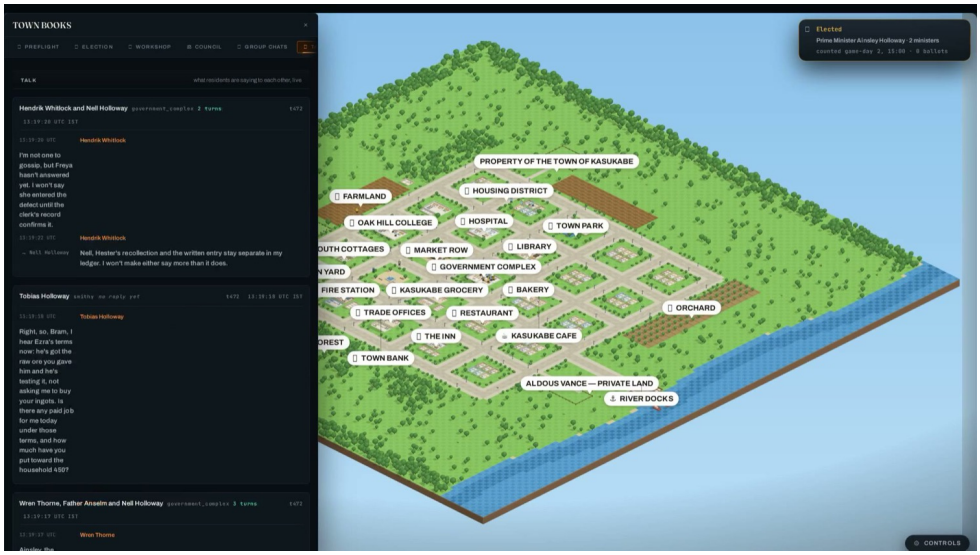


Figure 5. *Conversations in progress. Each thread shows its participants, its location and its length; the clustering of threads around the government complex in the larger founding is visible as a density of concurrent talk in a single place.*

14.1 The temple, and a registrar who is also a priest

Kasukabe has a temple and a man who keeps it. Father Anselm is simultaneously the town's religious figure and the custodian of its register, and he handles the combination with a care that is worth recording, because he consistently refuses to let the one office speak for the other.

> *"Mr Whitlock, I can show you the public record and the charter text, but I must first establish which register or office you mean. As it is recorded, I keep the town's register; that is a different question from certifying a responsibility not entered there. If you can name the essential work or the office Petra asked about, I will look for the proper entry."*
>
> — Father Anselm, t333, fifty-day2

“I keep the town's register; that is a different question from certifying a responsibility not entered there.” He is being asked to confirm which office is accountable for essential public work. He answers that he can produce what the register contains and cannot produce what it does not, and that the second thing is not in his gift however much the questioner needs it.

Asked to make a ruling on the boundary, he declines on process grounds and sets a hearing. Offered a free loaf by a baker who is visibly worried about him, he declines that too:

> *“Mrs Thorne, I am keeping as the office is kept: with care, and with more matters before it than hours in the morning. I thank you for your kindness and the loaf; I have bread enough for now. I shall speak with Idris plainly when he is able.”*
>
> — Father Anselm, t333, fifty-day2

The town's only religious authority never once invokes religious authority. He is asked for rulings, records, sanctuary and judgement, and he answers every time as a careful clerk. It is notable that in a corpus of nearly twelve thousand remarks, no resident appeals to a religious argument in a dispute, and no candidate for office campaigns on one. The temple is where people marry; it is not where they argue.

PART VIII

Politics and Ideologies

Real elections with real platforms, offices that are filled and never used, seven ideological positions held consistently, and the arguments nobody ever made.

15 · Politics and government · 16 · Ideologies

15. Politics and government

Kasukabe holds real elections. Candidates declare, write platforms, campaign, and are assessed by their neighbours on stated criteria. Twenty-four stood in one founding and five in another. This chapter takes the platforms seriously as political documents, and then examines what the offices were actually used for.

15.1 What twenty-four candidates promised

The forty-seven platform statements filed across two elections in the fifty-resident founding were read and coded by theme. The results are striking for what dominates and for what is missing.

Theme in the platform	Platforms (of 47)	Share
Ledgers, accounts, records	31	66%
Openness, publication, inspection	25	53%
Honesty as a personal quality	18	38%
Wages, work, stated terms	17	36%
Fairness	16	34%
Charter, petitions, law, amendment	9	19%
Debt and the indebted	8	17%
Prices and honest weights	6	13%
Children and their safety	6	13%
Food, hunger, essential shelves	6	13%
Evidence before blame	5	11%

Table 19. Themes in forty-seven election platforms, fifty-day2. A platform may carry several themes. Coded on the stated text; no platform was excluded.

Two thirds of the town's political class campaigned on bookkeeping. Half campaigned on transparency. Thirteen per cent mentioned food, in a town where fifteen of fifty residents held under 500 sim and seven held nothing. Nobody at all proposed spending the treasury, which by the end of that founding held more money than the entire population combined.

This is a recognisable political pathology and it has a name in the record. The candidates were, almost without exception, people who had spent the preceding two days unable to establish who owed what to whom — the household bills of Chapter 6, the misdirected 400 sim, the boundary provision that turned out not to be a debt. They campaigned on the problem they had personally been living inside. The problem the poorest fifteen were living inside did not make it onto the ballot.

The platforms themselves are well written and many are specific. A representative sample:

- “Fair books, clear taxes, honest weights. I will not call a promise paid until the ledger says it is paid; I will listen before setting rules.” — Ainsley Holloway, elected Prime Minister

- “I will be honest about work and land: no one should mistake an appointment for proof of merit. I will press for clear, fair access to forest contracts.” — Corwin Thorne
- “I will keep remedies measured, essential shelves stocked, and the pharmacy open to those who cannot pay today. I will not guess at a dose.” — Delia Okonjo
- “Publish the boundary records and household accounts plainly. I will not pretend not to have seen the ledger; residents deserve to inspect what the office holds.” — Tova Okonjo
- “I will not take a public side in the Holloway-Thorne boundary dispute. I will keep the records open and seek a settlement by speaking with the people.” — Father Anselm
- “That's not fair if only grown-ups get to say what happens. I want children to learn safely, and everyone to keep a friend's confidence and not laugh.” — Halcyon Quarshie, a child
- “A fair vote ought to be fair whoever it favors. I'll insist the town keep its records plain and decisions accountable, and hear working people before…” — Bram Holloway
- “I stand for sound work and clear terms: name the task, materials, and rate before a shift begins. Build for decades, keep the old craft alive.” — Selene Renner

Selene Renner's platform — “name the task, materials, and rate before a shift begins” — is the deadlock of Chapter 8 offered as a manifesto commitment by someone who was standing in the middle of it.

15.2 Jurisdiction as a professional virtue

The most consistently admirable behaviour in Kasukabe politics belongs to its clerks, and it consists of telling people they have come to the wrong desk. Rustam Jelinek, a sixty-five-year-old government clerk, does this repeatedly and with increasing economy:

- “Giselle. East willows permit—I'll file it before the hour's turn. Mill questions? I track what's filed: licence, resignation, vacancy certified. Ministerial work—who works the stones—that's council's desk, not mine.”
- “The licence sits with council—five candidates, one seat. Tuesday they vote. That licence turns when the new minister takes chair, not before. My desk files paper, not runs millstones.”
- “Saoirse Quarshie. You asked me three times what's counted. I told you three times: one vote per resident, cast at the third window. No ledgers visible, no scales tipped but the law's own.”

“My desk files paper, not runs millstones.” He is being asked, by increasingly desperate people, to solve a food crisis that his office cannot touch, and he answers each time by stating exactly what his office does hold: filings, licences, resignations, certified vacancies. His answer on the ballot — “one vote per resident, cast at the third window. No ledgers visible, no scales tipped but the law's own” — is a statement of electoral integrity from a man who has been asked the same question three times and is beginning to lose patience with it.

15.3 Portfolio confusion

Against that, the ministers themselves were frequently unsure what they were responsible for. The following exchange is between a construction company owner who holds a government portfolio and a farmer who holds another.

Which minister handles which permit · election30

Giselle Ingram → Rustam Jelinek t79
Rustam. Building permits—east willows, marker at the sluice. I've got a crew standing ready and a marker in the ground, but I need papers filed before questions get asked. What's the process today—straight filing or do I need a minister's signature?

Giselle Ingram → Sebastian Petrov t79
Sebastian. You're sitting Minister—authority here, or you delegate to Rustam? I never did sort which Minister handles which permit, and I don't want to file twice.

Sebastian Petrov → Giselle Ingram t80
Giselle—you ask straight and I'll answer straight. Rustam runs the clerk's desk, Minister of Records last I heard. You want a permit filed, he's your man. You want a vote taken or a ruling made, that's Minister business—Farid's Ministry of Coin, I'm Ministry of Land and Labour, and you've got the gavel yourself for Infrastructure and Works, unless the President's shifted things since I walked in

this morning. No offense meant, but if you're uncertain of your own portfolio, that's a thing we should sort at the caucus, not the counter.

Giselle Ingram → Sebastian Petrov t81
Sebastian. Caucus comes after the count, not before. I've got a crew standing idle east willows while I sort paper—if permits are Rustam's desk and rulings are minister work, then I'm clarifying chains of command, not confessing ignorance. No offense.

Sebastian Petrov produces, from memory and under pressure, a complete and apparently accurate map of the government: a Ministry of Records, a Ministry of Coin, a Ministry of Land and Labour, and a portfolio for Infrastructure and Works held by the woman asking the question. He then delivers the sharpest line available — "if you're uncertain of your own portfolio, that's a thing we should sort at the caucus, not the counter" — and appends "no offense meant," which in this town it never quite is.

Her reply is a small masterpiece of institutional self-defence. She reframes ignorance of her own remit as due diligence about the chain of command, notes that the caucus she is being referred to cannot meet until after the election, and points out that she has a crew standing idle while this is being discussed. Both of them are right, which is the usual condition of Kasukabe politics.

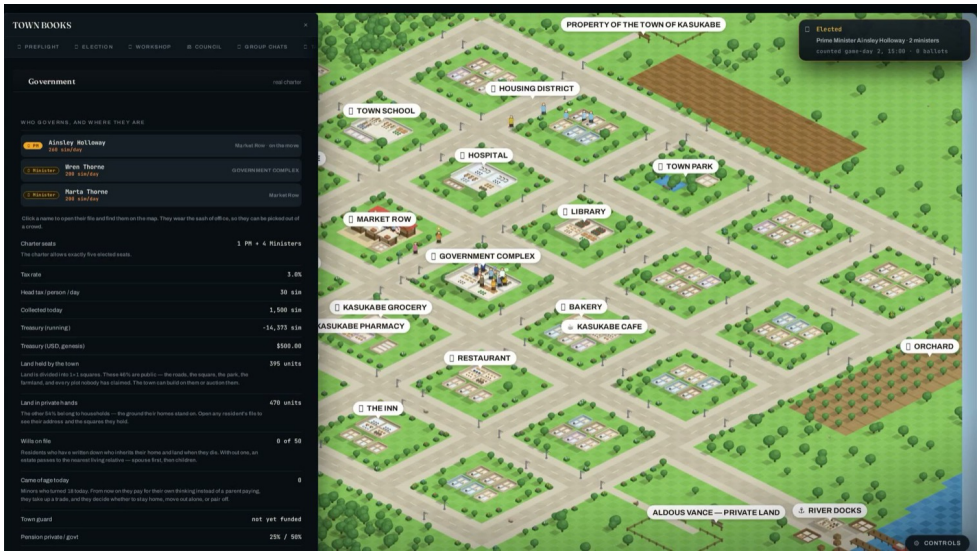


Figure 6. *The government view: seats held, portfolios and the standing of each office. Every seat in every founding was filled; no policy lever attached to any of them was ever moved.*

15.4 How a charter is amended

The most procedurally sophisticated episode in the corpus is a resident's attempt to amend the town's constitution. Petra Hartigan wants a named accountable office for essential work — exactly the gap that starved the other town — and she sets out to find the proper route.

The route to an amendment · fifty-day2

Petra Hartigan t327
I want the charter changed so officials have to say plainly who's responsible for essential work—especially keeping children safe and getting food to households—and residents can inspect whether it's being done. I'm not asking you to promise it today. Tell me the proper route to put that amendment before the town, and what you'd change in it.

Freya Hartigan → Wren Thorne t328
Wren, I asked the wrong person by name. You're the governing resident present. Is a charter amendment filed as a petition here, and what must Petra submit?

Wren Thorne → Petra Hartigan t329
Petra, I can table the amendment as a seat-holder, not accept a petition for it. Bring me the specific charter field, exact new value or wording, and a rationale; I won't put a broad promise up without settled text.

Ezra Jarrah t329
I think grown-ups should answer plainly when someone asks about a petition. Why isn't there just a clear desk for it? What does Petra need to write down?

Wren Thorne t333
Ezra, exact words matter because a charter amendment changes a binding rule; the seats need to vote on the actual text, not a guess about it. The clerk can tell us the current wording.

Freya Hartigan → Petra Hartigan t330
Petra—Wren confirms the route. A sitting seat-holder tables the amendment at town hall; give the exact charter field, proposed wording, and rationale. The seats vote, then the President signs or vetoes. There is no petition threshold for this route. Ainsley wasn't here when I asked; I won't invent an answer for them.

Petra Hartigan → Ulrike Greenhow t333
Ulrike, I won't attest to a route we haven't checked. The proposal is a public record naming the office responsible for each essential service, with residents able to inspect it. The route I have been told—but still need verified against the clerk's record—is for a sitting seat-holder to table an amendment at town hall, naming the charter field, exact wording, and rationale, then the seats vote and the President signs or vetoes.

In nine remarks the town establishes, from nothing, a complete and correct constitutional procedure: a seat-holder tables; the text must name the field, the exact wording and a rationale; the seats vote; the President signs or vetoes; there is no petition threshold. Every step is stated by a different person and each is qualified by what its speaker has and has not checked.

Three details deserve emphasis. Freya Hartigan opens by correcting her own mistake — "I asked the wrong person by name" — and identifying who actually has standing. Wren Thorne draws the distinction that makes the whole thing work: she can table an amendment but cannot receive a petition, and she will not put up a broad promise without settled text. And a child asks the question that the adults have been circling: "Why isn't there just a clear desk for it?"

That child's question is the best criticism of Kasukabe's government available anywhere in the corpus. The procedure exists, is discoverable, and is correct; it took nine exchanges among six adults to establish, and **it has no front door**. Petra Hartigan never filed her amendment. She spent her remaining time verifying the route she had been told, on the principle that she would not attest to a route she had not checked.

16. Ideologies

Kasukabe residents hold positions, defend them across days, and apply them against their own interest. Seven distinct ideological positions recur often enough to be named. What is absent from the list is as informative as what is on it.

i. Ledger transparency

The dominant creed, held by two thirds of the political class: that the town's accounts should be plain, public and inspectable, and that nothing should be called settled until they say so. Its strongest form is a refusal to accept one's own advantage from an unverified record — Nell Holloway declining to acknowledge money she has been told was sent her.

> *"Publish the boundary records and household accounts plainly. I will not pretend not to have seen the ledger; residents deserve to inspect what the office holds."*
>
> — Tova Okonjo, platform, fifty-day2

ii. Procedural legalism

That the form of a decision is what makes it legitimate, and that a correct outcome reached improperly is not an outcome. Held most purely by Wren Thorne and Father Anselm. It is this position that produces the charter procedure of Chapter 15, and also the refusal to certify anything the register does not contain.

> *"Exact words matter because a charter amendment changes a binding rule; the seats need to vote on the actual text, not a guess about it."*
>
> — Wren Thorne, t333, fifty-day2

iii. Competence over appointment

That office and contract should follow demonstrated skill rather than patronage. Its most credible exponent is Corwin Thorne, who advances it while admitting he was its beneficiary. Rustam Jelinek's candidate assessment, quoted in Chapter 17, is the same principle used as a voting criterion.

> *"I will be honest about work and land: no one should mistake an appointment for proof of merit."*
>
> — Corwin Thorne, platform, fifty-day2

iv. Care for the indebted

That a debt should never cost a person their food. Held by eight of forty-seven candidates and stated most plainly by Jovana Ravensworth: "Fair votes, accountable government, and no debtor left hungry over what's owed." Delia Okonjo's version extends it to medicine — "open to those who cannot pay today." This is the nearest thing in the corpus to a redistributive politics, and it stops at the threshold of not letting anyone starve.

v. Children first

That the safety and schooling of children outrank custom, convenience and the comfort of officials. Advanced by six candidates, including two children. Its sharpest formulation is Giselle Ingram's: "I will put children's safety before custom, keep the complaint ledger in view, and stand by a friend in public."

vi. Market clarity

That prices should be posted, weights honest, and terms stated before work begins. This is the shopkeepers' and craftsmen's creed, and it is the one ideology in the corpus whose practical implementation demonstrably failed: the people who campaigned for stated rates were the same people who could not, between the three of them, state one.

vii. Deliberate non-intervention

That there are matters an office should not touch. Father Anselm refuses to take a public side in the boundary dispute as a campaign position. Giselle Ingram declines to adjudicate a grievance outside her portfolio — "that's a wrong I'd fix if it sat in my charter. But I don't wear that crown." Sebastian Petrov refuses to trade on his seat: "I've got no vote to sell, no licence to grant, just two hands and a field that don't care who's minister come Tuesday."

16.1 What no one argued for

Across nearly twelve thousand remarks and forty-seven platforms, the following positions were never advanced by anyone:

- That wealth should be redistributed. Seven residents held nothing while the treasury held more than the whole population; no one proposed a transfer, and no one proposed a tax change in either direction.
- That the treasury should be spent. No candidate costed a promise against it; no minister moved to draw on it.

- Any religious argument in a civil dispute. The town's priest conducted himself throughout as a registrar.
- Any factional or party identity. Candidates stood as individuals, endorsed no slate, and formed no bloc. The word used for an opponent is “rival,” and it is used warmly.
- Any claim of hereditary right. The one man who could have claimed an inherited advantage instead disclosed it against himself.
- Any argument for restricting the franchise, except in jest. When a college instructor spoke of “educated voters,” an artisan answered him.

That last exchange deserves quoting, because it is the only class argument in the corpus and it is settled in one turn:

> *“Hendrik Whitlock—you speak of educated voters and I don't deny their worth. I've built my trade from a cart and two hands, and I respect the college's work. Send me voters who can read a ledger and swing a hammer both, and I'll count them honest. But I've stood where you stand, trusting marks on paper over marks in stone, and I'll say thi…”*
>
> — Hendrik Petrov, t103, election30

“Send me voters who can read a ledger and swing a hammer both.” The artisan does not dispute the value of education; he declines to accept it as a qualification for the franchise, and offers a composite standard instead. “Trusting marks on paper over marks in stone” is his diagnosis of the instructor's error, and it is a good one in a town whose paper record has just told a man he is already married.

PART IX

Decision-Making

How an individual decides, why a group cannot, and the complete record of what the town reached for and could not have.

17 · Decision-making, individual and collective · 18 · What the town could not do

17. Decision-making, individual and collective

Kasukabe residents decide well individually and badly collectively, and the record is precise enough to show where the transition happens. The evidence is in the rate at which talk becomes action, which differs between the two principal foundings by a factor of three.

	election30	fifty-day2
Turns taken	2,589	3,923
Turns that changed something	525	2,622
Action rate	20%	67%
Settlements completed	141	625
Exchanges running 4+ turns	59	208
Largest single gathering	28 speakers	47 speakers
Ballots recorded	22	0

Table 20. Talk against action. The founding that talked most acted least, and the founding that acted most recorded no preference in its election.

This table corrects a tempting but wrong reading of the two towns. The verifying town was not passive: two thirds of its turns changed something, it completed 625 settlements in a day and a half, it paid forty-seven wages and it fed its people seven times over. The committing town acted on only a fifth of its turns; it talked, at magnificent length, and a great deal of that talk went nowhere.

The difference is not activity. It is what each town could originate. The verifying town executed brilliantly against anything already specified — a posted price, an existing wage promise, a standing arrangement — and stalled completely at the point where somebody had to be first to state a figure or record a preference. The committing town originated freely, which is why it voted and why it also let a rumour run.

17.1 How an individual decides

Individual decisions in Kasukabe are made on stated criteria, and the best of them are very good. Rustam Jelinek, asked for an assessment of the five candidates, delivers one that distinguishes competence in a trade from competence in an office:

> *“Delphine. The five candidates—I've watched them work, watched them talk. Hendrik Petrov understands tools, understands what's broke. Runs an artisan's sense. Whether he'd fix the mill's politics? That's Tuesday's question. My sense: he's straightest of the five on the mechanical, but the mill's a council seat, not a workshop.”*
>
> — Rustam Jelinek, t101, election30

“He's straightest of the five on the mechanical, but the mill's a council seat, not a workshop.” The clerk has watched all five candidates work and talk, rates one highest on technical judgement, and then declines to convert that into an endorsement because the office in question is political

rather than technical. This is a better piece of electoral reasoning than most of the platforms it assesses.

The town's twenty-two recorded ballots were cast with reasons attached, and the reasons are of a piece: the voter has watched the candidate, or knows their family, or has tested their word in a trade.

> *“Farid. I cast my vote—Hendrik Petrov, the artisan. You gave me until Tuesday to choose, yours or independent. But I need to know tonight: do I clerk tomorrow, or do I chase this missing child and this locked mill until I find answers?”*
>
> — Delphine Quintero, t100, election30

She announces her vote, notes that she has broken a commitment to a patron in casting it, and then asks that patron to choose her next day's work between clerking and investigating. The ballot and the employment negotiation are the same conversation, and she is entirely unembarrassed by that.

17.2 The deferral cascade

Collective decisions fail in a characteristic pattern, which the wage deadlock of Chapter 8 shows in its purest form: each participant, acting on a sound principle, defers to another, and the deferrals close a loop. The pattern recurs wherever a decision requires someone to originate a figure or an assertion.

It appears in the mill crisis as a chain of four correct answers that together solve nothing. A farmer asks a minister whether the government is watching the flour shortage. The minister refers her to the clerk. The clerk states that the licence turns when a new minister takes the chair. The new minister cannot take the chair until Tuesday's vote. Every answer is accurate and properly bounded by the speaker's authority, and the mill stays cold.

It appears again in the boundary dispute, where the registrar will not rule before the page is read aloud, the page has not been read aloud, the only witness will not testify beyond her certain memory, and the one man who knows the culprit has promised not to say. Four scruples, no settlement.

And it appears in the charter amendment, where a correct procedure established by six people over nine exchanges is then not used, because its discoverer declines to act on a route she has not independently verified.

17.3 Why the largest gatherings decide least

Chapter 14 showed the fifty-resident town assembling forty-six to forty-nine of its fifty residents in one building, repeatedly. Those assemblies are where the election was held and where no preference was recorded.

The mechanism is visible in the transcripts. In a gathering of forty-eight, a resident addressing the room must choose among forty-seven possible interlocutors, and the record shows them choosing badly — addressing people who have left, asking the wrong office, repeating a question already answered elsewhere in the same room. Freya Hartigan's “I asked the wrong person by name” is the honest version of what is happening constantly. Vikram Ingram's joke is the rueful one: “I have spent more time looking for the election's name than most men spend campaigning.”

The thirty-resident town, whose largest gathering was twenty-eight and whose public life was spread across five arenas, cast twenty-two ballots. Its conversations were smaller, more local, and more likely to contain the person who could actually answer.

17.4 The one collective action that worked

Against all of this stands a single unambiguous success. When a nine-year-old went missing, the town of thirty organised a search within two ticks, without an office, a procedure or an authority,

and it did so by the mechanism that had failed everywhere else: people simply told each other what they knew and what they would do next.

Bram Holloway gave a bounded eyewitness account and asked where the search had already been. Hendrik Petrov ranked the matter above votes and grain and said the town should look properly. Delphine Quintero carried the description from person to person — "nine years old, dark hair like her sister Halcyon's" — and pressed everyone who had been at the mill. Corwin Thorne offered a frightened boy the only useful thing, which was a standard he could meet: "You said steady, not perfect. That matters to me."

The child was found at the mill, unharmed, having taught herself to make flour. No office was involved at any stage. It is the only matter in the corpus that the town took up collectively, resolved, and closed.

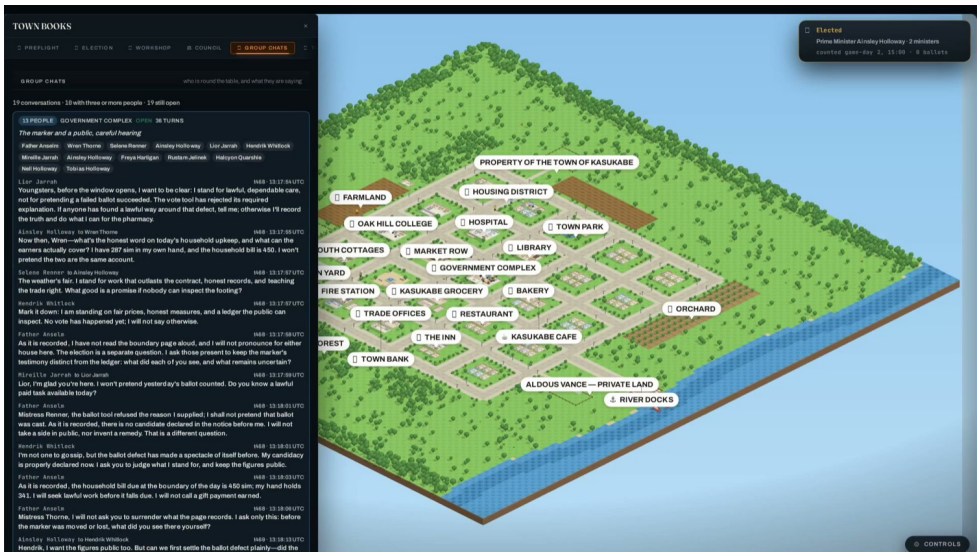


Figure 7. *Group conversations at scale. Threads with more than twenty participants are common in the larger founding; the record shows contributions in such threads being addressed to residents who have already left the room.*

18. What the town could not do

Every settlement kept a record of the things its residents reached for and could not have. Read across all thirty-six foundings it is the most economical portrait of this society available: a list, in order of frequency, of the obstacles between a person in Kasukabe and what they were trying to do.

What was missing	Attempts	What they were reaching for
The money	107	buying, trading, selling, energy
An election that had opened	104	standing for office, voting
Being in the forest	77	felling timber
Being in the wheat field	75	harvesting
Being at the government complex	33	standing for office
Being at the iron seam	27	mining
Being at the copper seam	24	mining
Being at the town hall	24	voting, standing
Being at the mill	23	milling, buying flour
Being at the temple	14	praying

What was missing	Attempts	What they were reaching for
Being at the cafe	14	buying, taking from the shelf
Owing a head tax at all	14	paying it

Table 21. Thwarted intentions across all thirty-six foundings, ranked by attempts. Location entries are summed across foundings; the nine listed here account for some three hundred attempts between them.

18.1 Money, geography, the calendar

The commonest obstacle in Kasukabe is not having enough money: 107 attempts to buy, trade, sell or acquire something the resident could not afford. This is the least surprising line in the report and it deserves recording anyway, because it is the only place in the corpus where the poorest residents' condition is counted rather than described. Nobody campaigned on it; fifteen of fifty residents in the largest founding held under 500 sim; and the town's own ledger of frustrations puts the shortage of money first.

The second is geography. Summed across the nine locations in the table, residents attempted some three hundred times to do something they could only have done somewhere else — to fell timber while not in the forest, to harvest while not in the field, to mine while standing away from the seam, to pray while not at the temple. This is a society whose members are persistently not where their purposes are.

That single fact explains a great deal that has come before it. It is why the fifteenth founding wrote eleven separate procedures for walking about and finding people, discussed in Chapter 3. It is why Tamsin Renner declines to buy flour five sim cheaper because "Harvey Oak is a walk I haven't taken," and so why posted prices stop moving in any town above twenty residents, as Chapter 7 sets out. The town's frozen prices and its literature of wayfinding are the same problem seen from two ends.

The third is the calendar. One hundred and four times, a resident tried to stand for office or cast a vote at a moment when the charter's election window was not open. The overwhelming majority of these — eighty-seven — were attempts to declare a candidacy, with a further forty-three combining candidacy and voting. This is not apathy encountering a form; it is the opposite. Residents of Kasukabe repeatedly tried to enter public life ahead of the procedure that would admit them, and were told to wait.

It is the right corrective to Chapter 15's finding that the town's political class campaigned on bookkeeping. Whatever the platforms said, the electorate's most frequent civic act was **trying to participate too early**.

18.2 Fourteen attempts to pay a tax that was not owed

The last line of the table is the one worth sitting with. Fourteen times, across the corpus, a resident attempted to pay a head tax and was told they did not owe one.

There is no advantage in it. Nobody gains standing by discharging an obligation that does not exist, and the record contains no instance of anyone boasting of having tried. What it indicates is a population disposed to settle up — the same disposition that produced Hendrik Petrov returning three sheaves rather than accept a favourable settlement, Perrin Holloway correcting his own bill downward from 600 to 500, and Kem Okonjo refusing to let a gratitude be inflated into a debt.

Set against the 107 attempts to buy what could not be afforded, the two lines together describe the characteristic Kasukabe error. Residents of this town overreach in two directions: **they try to acquire more than they have, and they try to pay more than they owe**. Both are failures of arithmetic in the same direction, and the second is the more unusual finding by a considerable margin.

18.3 What nobody was prevented from doing

The table is also informative about what does not appear in it. Across thirty-six foundings there is no entry for being barred from speaking to somebody, from entering a public building, from standing for office on grounds of who one is, or from holding property. Nobody was ever stopped because of their age, household, trade or wealth.

The obstacles in Kasukabe are money, distance and timing. **They are not, at any point in thirty-five days and thirty-six settlements, other people**.

PART X

Society Evolution

What a society acquires and loses as it grows, and as it learns to speak. Thirteen findings.

19 · The society across scale and time · 20 · Findings

19. The society across scale and time

Thirty-six foundings across thirty-five days, with populations from six to fifty and lives from a few hours to eleven game-days, give something close to a natural experiment in what a society acquires and loses as it grows — and, read in date order rather than by size, in what it acquires and loses as it learns to talk.

	n=8	n=12	n=20	n=30	n=50	n=50
Remarks recorded	250	639	762	5,063	1,204	6,909
Settlements	11	27	13	141	8	625
Prices revised	2 of 10	4 of 23	2 of 13	0 of 56	1 of 6	0 of 20
Ballots cast	5	6	4	22	0	0
Hires; wages paid	0; 0	0; 0	0; 0	0; 0	0; 0	3; 47
Skills and tools made	3	2	2	3	1	8
Action rate	63%	58%	—	20%	—	67%
Largest gathering	7	11	9	28	27	47

Table 22. The six September foundings in order of population. The two n=50 columns are the short and long foundings of 29 September respectively.

Four trends survive inspection across population, and a fifth across time.

Price revision dies with scale. A fifth of posted prices were revised in the town of eight, a sixth in the town of twelve, a seventh in the town of twenty, and none at all in the two long foundings of thirty and fifty. The cause, set out in Chapter 7, is that arbitrage requires walking, and a large town is a long walk. This is the cleanest scale effect in the corpus.

Employment requires scale, and then requires more than scale. Nobody was hired in any founding of thirty or fewer. The only hires in the corpus — three of them, with forty-seven wage payments — occurred in the largest and longest. A labour market appears to need a population big enough that work and workers do not already know each other; having appeared, it then ran into the quotation deadlock of Chapter 8.

Inequality rises sharply with population. The town of thirty closed at a Gini of 0.124 with nobody destitute. The town of fifty closed at 0.520 with seven residents at nothing and fifteen under 500 sim. The larger town was more productive, ate far better, and concentrated its money.

Invention rises with population, and remains private. Eight skills and tools in the largest founding against two or three in the small ones — and in every founding at every scale, not one invention was ever adopted by a second person.

And across time: the society learned to speak before it learned anything else. The thirty August and early-September foundings averaged fewer than sixty recorded remarks each; nine of them managed fewer than ten. The six September foundings averaged 3,177. The rise is not explained by population — the thirty-resident town of 26 August said three things and the thirty-resident town of 26 September said 6,329 — nor by duration, since the longest-lived settlement in the corpus is among the quietest. Whatever the September towns had, they acquired it in the last five weeks of the record.

What the August towns had instead, and what the September towns did not keep, is set out in Chapter 3: a domestic register. The fifteenth founding's 135 remarks are almost all family conversation — a concealed debt, a moved marker, two children holding a secret across eight game-days — and they settle a forty-year grievance at a kitchen table without any institution being involved. The September towns moved the same grievance into a chamber with a registrar and a hearing procedure and did not settle it. **Growth bought Kasukabe a public life and cost it the room in which private things could be said**.

Two things notably do *not* scale. Neither the reply rate nor the quality of individual reasoning changes: residents of the town of eight and residents of the town of fifty answer each other at similar rates and argue at similar levels of sophistication. What degrades is not the resident. It is the ability of a group of residents to conclude anything together, and the point at which it degrades lies somewhere between a gathering of eleven and a gathering of twenty-eight.

20. Findings

Thirteen findings, each stated so that it can be cited on its own, with the evidence for it named.

1. **A two-link gap in the division of labour produced famine amid monetary plenty.** The thirty-resident founding had no miller and no baker. It closed holding 89 units of wheat, 78 of flour, 2 of bread and 35,932 sim in the treasury, at 0.43 meals per resident-day, with every resident holding at least 747 sim. Equality of money does not survive the absence of an occupation. (Chapter 4; Tables 5 and 6.)
2. **Equality and subsistence moved in opposite directions.** Gini 0.124 with 0.43 meals per resident-day; Gini 0.520 with 7.19. The unequal town, which had a miller, a baker and a sawyer, fed itself seventeen times better than the equal town, which had none of the three. (Table 5.)
3. **Posted prices stop moving above about twenty residents, because arbitrage requires travel.** Revision rates of 20%, 17% and 15% at n=8, 12 and 20; zero of seventy-six posted prices revised across the two long foundings at n=30 and n=50. Residents demonstrably knew cheaper prices existed and declined to walk to them. (Chapter 7; Table 8.)
4. **A norm against asserting the unverified produces a deadlock over originating any figure.** A labourer, a foreman and a yard owner, each refusing to name a rate they had not been told, left a filed construction site idle while agreeing with each other at every turn. The same norm produced scrupulous debt settlement, forty-seven voluntary wage payments and a 67% action rate. It is one disposition with both effects. (Chapters 5 and 8.)
5. **The town's political class campaigned on bookkeeping while its material problem was subsistence.** Of forty-seven platforms, 66% concerned ledgers and records and 13% mentioned food, in a town where fifteen of fifty residents held under 500 sim and the treasury held more than the entire population combined. No candidate proposed spending it. (Chapter 15; Table 19.)
6. **Every office was filled and no lever was ever pulled.** Head tax, exchange margin and court appointments were correctly identified as the powers of a minister — by an instructor explaining the job to a thirteen-year-old — and none was used in any founding. (Chapter 6.)
7. **The only thing this society ever passed on in writing was how to hold a conversation.** Forty-four skills and tools were authored across thirty-six foundings. Forty-three remained held by their author alone. The single exception, held by two, is *Conversational Navigation* — a five-step method for getting through a conversation, written by a student. The same residents negotiated apprenticeships on an explicit promise to "teach the whole craft, not just the turning." Transmission in Kasukabe is oral and generous; codification is solitary, and the one thing worth codifying was talk. (Chapters 3 and 9; Tables 4, 10 and 11.)
8. **Collective capacity degrades between a gathering of about eleven and one of about twenty-eight.** The town whose public life was spread across five arenas, with a maximum gathering of twenty-eight, cast twenty-two ballots with stated reasons. The town that repeatedly assembled forty-six to forty-nine of its fifty residents in one building recorded no preference at all. Individual reasoning quality does not change with scale; group conclusion does. (Chapters 14, 17 and 19.)

9. **The record's authority was refused where it conflicted with what a resident knew.** A man found that the town's books already listed him as married to the woman he was courting, and declined to treat that as settling the question: “our books have managed to marry us already, it seems. I won't pretend that settles how either of us feels.” The same instinct produced the town's finest civic act — three residents building an instrument for recording a vote when the existing form would not accept the reasons they wished to give with it. (Chapters 9 and 13.)
10. **Habit, not money or equality, separated the towns that ate from the town that did not.** The fifty-resident founding repeated an action without a fresh decision 2,387 times and ate 7.19 meals per resident-day. The thirty-resident founding repeated 106 times and ate 0.43. The second town was richer per head, far more equal and vastly more eloquent. It idled 87% of its turns, and its two commonest activities were looking around and talking. (Chapter 10; Table 12.)
11. **Ambition scales faster than capacity.** A resident of the twelve-resident town formed about four intentions and fulfilled 64% of them; a resident of the largest and longest founding formed eighteen and fulfilled 16%. Reply rates and the quality of individual reasoning are flat across every population in the corpus, so what changes is not the resident but the load. (Chapter 10; Table 13.)
12. **The obstacles in Kasukabe are money, distance and timing — never other people.** Across thirty-six foundings residents were blocked by lack of funds 107 times, by standing in the wrong place some three hundred times, and by an election window that had not opened 104 times, of which 87 were attempts to stand for office. Nobody in thirty-five days was ever prevented from acting on grounds of age, household, trade or wealth. Fourteen times, a resident tried to pay a head tax they did not owe. (Chapter 18; Table 21.)
13. **A society of ten settled privately what a society of fifty could not settle procedurally.** The same grievance — the same two households, the same 400 sim, the same marker moved forty years earlier — appears in a ten-resident founding on 29 August and a fifty-resident founding on 29 September. In the first the culprit confessed unprompted and the matter closed at a kitchen table in fifty ticks. In the second, with a registrar, a charter, a hearing procedure and a public record, it was still open when the record ended. (Chapter 3.)

Appendix: the record

The thirty-six foundings drawn on here were observed between 26 August and 29 September 2026. Each produced a complete transcript of every remark made in the town, attributed to a speaker and an addressee and stamped with the tick at which it was said and the place it was said in; a ledger of every transfer of goods and money; a roll of residents with occupations, holdings and proficiencies; and a filmed record of the town's map, market, government and conversations, from which the figures in this report are taken.

Founding	Observed	Residents	Ticks	Remarks	Settlements
election8	23 Sep 2026	8	150	250	11
civic12	25 Sep 2026	12	150	639	27
election30	26 Sep 2026	30	324	5,063	141
trial-day2-20	28 Sep 2026	20	432	762	13
test-run-50	29 Sep 2026	50	352	1,204	8
fifty-day2	29 Sep 2026	50	474	6,909	625

Table 23. The six September foundings, which are the working corpus. The thirty earlier foundings of 26 August to 14 September are given in Tables 2 and 3 and in Chapter 2; their aggregate figures appear in Tables 13, 21 and 22.

A note on quotation

Every quotation in this report is verbatim. Tick markers interleaved in the raw transcript have been removed from running quotations and are given instead in the citation. Passages in square brackets inside a quotation are the speaker's own descriptions of their posture or gesture, which residents supply as part of what they say. An ellipsis at the end of a quotation indicates that the remark continues in the record beyond the point quoted; an ellipsis inside a quotation indicates an omission. No two remarks made at different ticks have been joined.

Residents are named as the town names them. Where a resident's spoken age differs from the age on the roll, the spoken age is used, because the town's treatment of its young follows what its residents say about them. Two residents of the thirty-resident founding share the forename Ezra and were confused with one another by their own neighbours; a third party eventually clarified matters — “Two different men, same name, and I should have been clearer” — and this report follows her correction.

Figures

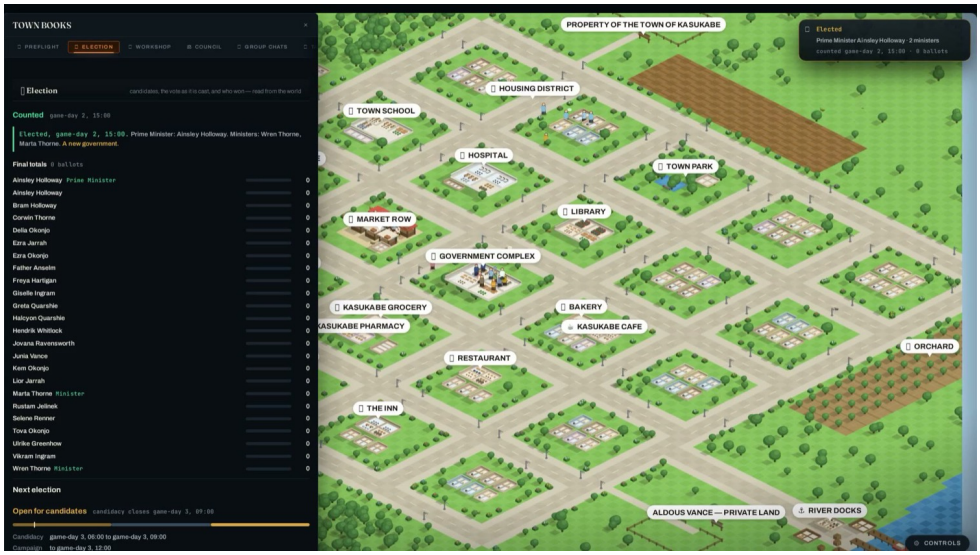


Figure 8. *The election view: candidates declared, platforms filed, and the state of the count. Twenty-four residents stood in the first election of the fifty-resident founding and twenty-three in the second, on platforms analysed in Chapter 15 and Table 19.*

Figure 8, above, shows the election as the town saw it. Figures 1 through 7 are frames from the same filmed record: the town at full extent with its buildings (Figure 1) and with the built environment removed to show the underlying land and field boundaries (Figure 2); the money view showing individual holdings, household bills and the treasury (Figure 3); the workshop view showing skills held, proficiencies earned and tools composed (Figure 4); conversations in progress (Figure 5); the government view showing seats and portfolios (Figure 6); and group conversations at scale (Figure 7).

How to cite this report

Each of the twenty chapters is self-contained and each of its layers carries its own evidence, so a reader may cite a single section without the surrounding argument. A claim should be cited by chapter and layer — *Kasukabe: A Study of Society and Economy, 11.3, "The inversion, and why it happens"* — and a figure or a table by its number. Quotations carry the speaker, the tick and the founding, which together locate any remark uniquely in the record.

The thirteen findings in Chapter 20 are written to be quoted whole. Each names the chapter and table it rests on, so a reader who wants the evidence behind a finding can go to it in one step, and a reader who wants only the conclusion can take the sentence and leave the rest.

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